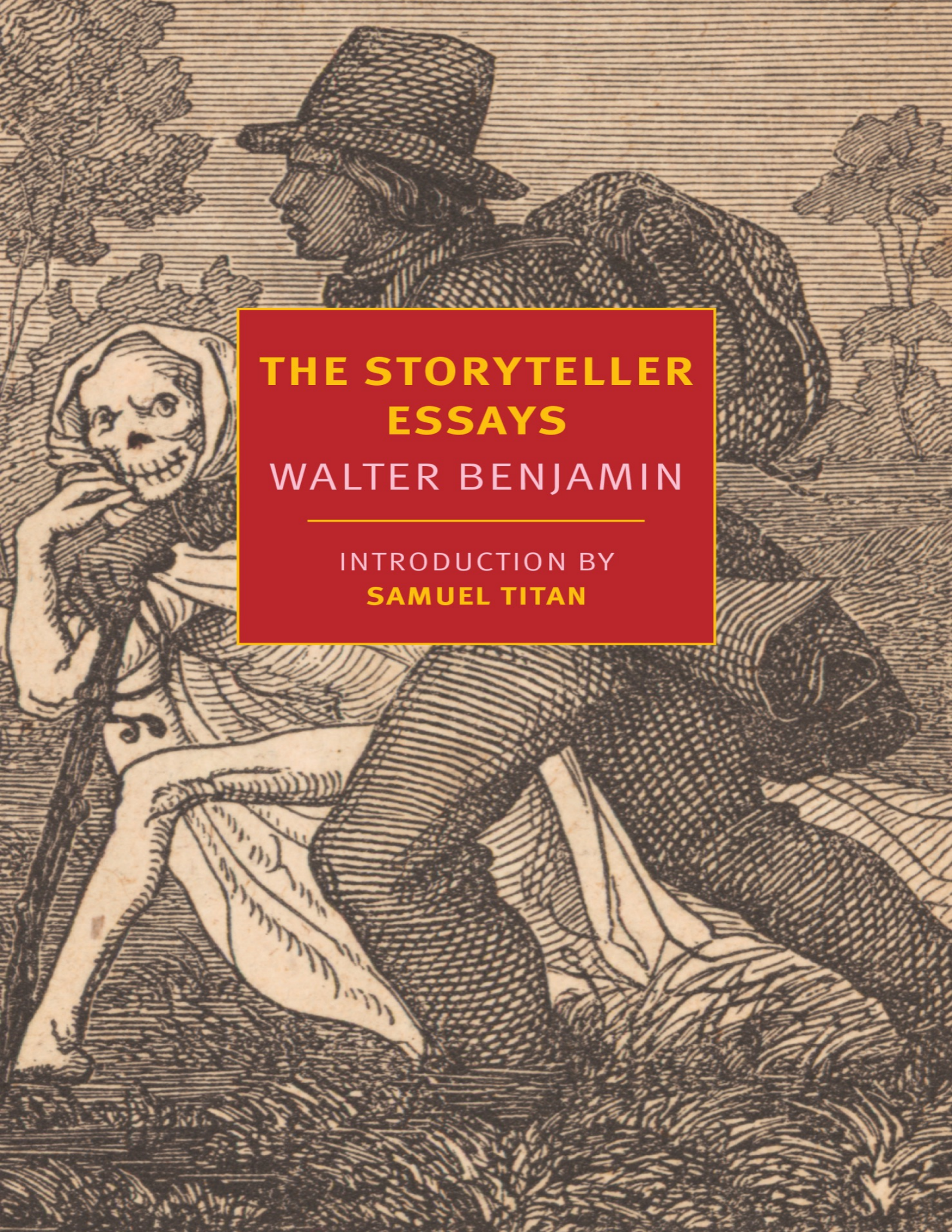


THE STORYTELLER ESSAYS

WALTER BENJAMIN

INTRODUCTION BY
SAMUEL TITAN

WALTER BENJAMIN (1892–1940) was the oldest of three siblings born to an intellectual Jewish family in Berlin. From 1912 to 1915, he studied philosophy at the Universities of Freiburg, Berlin, and Munich, befriending the young philosopher Gershom Scholem at the latter. In 1917, Benjamin transferred again, to the University of Bern, where he met and married Dora Sophie Kellner; their son, Stefan, was born in 1918. While working on the periphery of the academy, he wrote parables, criticism, and short stories; translated Baudelaire's *Tableau Parisien* and two volumes of Proust's *In Search of Lost Time*; made major contributions to twentieth-century criticism and thought in essays such as "The Task of the Translator," "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction," "The Paris of the Second Empire in Baudelaire," and "Theses on the Philosophy of History"; and worked on his unclassifiable and unfinished *Arcades Project*. After Hitler's rise to power, Benjamin fled Germany for Ibiza, Nice, and finally, Paris. In 1938 he was arrested and imprisoned in a furniture factory in Burgundy. After his release and the day before the Germans invaded Paris, he and his sister fled to Portbou, on the Spanish border. Carrying a leather suitcase with an unknown manu-script inside, Benjamin made the grueling crossing over the Pyrenees to Spain, where his request for entry was rejected by the local authorities; that night he committed suicide.

SAMUEL TITAN is an editor and translator based in Brazil. He teaches comparative literature at the University of São Paulo.

TESS LEWIS has translated works from the French and German, including books by Peter Handke, Anselm Kiefer, Philippe Jaccottet, and Christine Angot. Her awards include the 2017 PEN Translation Prize and a Guggenheim fellowship. She serves as the co-chair of the PEN Translation Committee and is an advisory editor for *The Hudson Review*.

THE STORYTELLER ESSAYS

WALTER BENJAMIN

Edited and with an introduction by

SAMUEL TITAN

Translated from the German by

TESS LEWIS

NEW YORK REVIEW BOOKS



New York

THIS IS A NEW YORK REVIEW BOOK
PUBLISHED BY THE NEW YORK REVIEW OF BOOKS
435 Hudson Street, New York, NY 10014
www.nyrb.com

Translation copyright © 2019 by Tess Lewis Introduction copyright © 2019 by Samuel Titan All rights reserved.

Cover image: Lorenz Frølich, *Tod und Wandrer* (Death and Wanderer), illustration from the Sächsischer Volkskalender for 1848; courtesy Universitäts- und Landesbibliothek Düsseldorf Cover design: Katy Homans

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data Names: Benjamin, Walter, 1892–1940, author. | Lewis, Tess, translator. | Titan, Samuel, editor, writer of introduction. | Benjamin, Walter, 1892–1940. Storytellers.
Title: The storyteller essays / by Walter Benjamin ; trans. by Tess Lewis ; edited and introduction by Samuel Titan.
Other titles: Walter Benjamin's Storytellers
Description: New York : New York Review Books, 2019. | Series: New York Review Books classics.
Identifiers: LCCN 2018036771 (print) | LCCN 2018058293 (ebook) | ISBN 9781681370590 (epub) | ISBN 9781681370583 (paperback) Subjects: LCSH: Benjamin, Walter, 1892–1940—Translations into English. | Benjamin, Walter, 1892–1940—Books and reading. | BISAC: LITERARY COLLECTIONS / Essays. | LITERARY CRITICISM / European / German. | FICTION / Short Stories (single author).
Classification: LCC PT2603.E455 (ebook) | LCC PT2603.E455 A2 2019 (print) | DDC 838/.91209—dc 3
LC record available at https://lccn.loc.gov/2018036771

ISBN 978-1-68137-059-0

v1.0

For a complete list of titles, visit www.nyrb.com or write to: Catalog Requests, NYRB, 435 Hudson Street, New York, NY 10014

CONTENTS

Introduction

THE STORYTELLER ESSAYS
Johann Peter Hebel
The Crisis of the Novel: On Döblin's *Berlin Alexanderplatz*
Mulberry Omelet
The Lisbon Earthquake
Oskar Maria Graf as Storyteller
On Proverbs
The Handkerchief
Storytelling and Healing
Reading Novels
The Art of Storytelling
By the Fire: On the Twenty-Fifth Anniversary of a Novel
Experience and Poverty
The Storyteller: Reflections on the Work of Nikolai Leskov

Writings by Others
Silence and Mirror by ERNST BLOCH
The Giant's Toy as Legend by ERNST BLOCH
The Embroidery of Marie Monnier by PAUL VALÉRY
From *The Theory of the Novel* by GEORG LUKÁCS
On Sadness by MICHEL DE MONTAIGNE
From *The Histories* by HERODOTUS
From *The Treasure Chest of the Rhenish Family Friend* by JOHANN PETER HEBEL

Selected Sources

INTRODUCTION

BOOKS have their fates, and the same probably applies to essays. The fate of "The Storyteller" is, in any case, a fine example of just how surprising the career of a text can be. The work of a German Jewish exile trying to scrape together a living after the Nazi takeover in 1933, it purports to discuss the stories of a great but lesser-read Russian writer—but then veers off into a number of other topics. The piece appeared in 1937 in the very last issue of an eccentric Swiss review, which counted a mere thirty-five subscribers at the time. Its author committed suicide three years later, as he fled occupied France, leaving behind a dispersed body of critical work and a formidable mass of unfinished manuscripts. None of this looks like the stuff a success story is made of, and yet Walter Benjamin's "The Storyteller" has become one of the best-known literary essays of the twentieth century. Widely familiar to students of literature, it is also regularly featured on reading lists in fields such as anthropology, media studies, and creative writing—a remarkable reversal of fate when one considers the essay's obscure beginnings.

Benjamin's renown owes much to the loyalty of the likes of Hannah Arendt, Theodor Adorno, and Georges Bataille, to name just a few of those who kept his memory alive after the war. His writings and correspondence were devoutly unearthed, footnoted, and printed in multiple formats, from cheap paperbacks for undergraduates to multivolume hardbound editions of his complete writings, both in German and in translation. Right now, Suhrkamp Verlag, Benjamin's publisher in his homeland, is halfway through its second take on his complete works, a densely annotated critical edition quite reminiscent of classical scholarship. Given that, why another collection of his essays—and, more to the point, why one like this, centered on "The Storyteller"?

•

The answer has to do exactly with the popularity of the essay, which all too often is presented as a stand-alone text, a brilliant piece of literary theory, or a poetic exercise in historical nostalgia that the reader can appreciate without, say, having to tackle Benjamin's dense dissertation *Origin of the*

German Trauerspiel or getting lost in the maze of his unfinished *Arcades Project*. The fluent prose of "The Storyteller," full of memorable formulations and striking images, tends to confirm this preconception, and indeed the essay seems to have taken shape unusually easily for Benjamin. Begun around late March 1936, it was probably finished by June, though it was only in the summer of the following year that it came out in Fritz Lieb's review *Orient und Occident*—quick work indeed when compared to the tortuous genesis of some of Benjamin's other major essays.

The essay and its origins are, however, more complicated than this would suggest. "The Storyteller" was the outcome of a long train of thought that goes back to Benjamin's student days in Berlin and gathers momentum in the second half of the 1920s. From 1926 to 1936, he published a number of pieces—essays, newspaper articles, book reviews, short stories, etc.—in which he tested concepts and probed images and observations that would finally converge in his critical portrait of Nikolai Leskov. *The Storyteller Essays* puts "The Storyteller" in the company of these texts, the better to chart the development of Benjamin's thoughts about three key concepts in the 1936 essay: experience, tradition, and storytelling. Read in the company of its forerunners, one can hear how "The Storyteller" resonates with his larger themes and recognize its place at the heart of his oeuvre, next to "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction" and the Baudelaire essays of the 1930s. Last but not least, this volume offers a revealing glimpse of the dynamics of Benjamin's writing: the way he tries out an idea in one context only to take it up again—sometimes quoting himself verbatim—in quite another; his manner of smuggling ideas from authors like Michel de Montaigne or Paul Valéry to reflect his own, different concerns; and his gift for aphorisms—phrases that he would sometimes polish over the course of years (for example, "Boredom is the dream bird that broods the egg of experience")—but equally for jarringly abrupt, montage-like transitions.

•

"The art of storytelling is dying out." The claim is presented early in "The Storyteller" as a matter of simple observation, born out, Benjamin writes, "almost every day." He swiftly renders this loss as the loss of "the most reliable of all our capacities," namely "the ability to share experiences," and

he puts a date on the phenomenon: soldiers came back from World War I battlefields "not richer in experiences they could share, but poorer." Established experience has been "refuted" on all fronts, first by mechanized warfare, later by runaway inflation and political turmoil, until only the "tiny, fragile human body" is left in the middle of a "force field" of "currents and explosions." Benjamin himself was no stranger to the consequences of those years of upheaval. Coming from a well-to-do, assimilated Jewish family, he had seen his means diminish, particularly after *Origin of the German Trauerspiel* was refused as a postdoctoral dissertation by the University of Frankfurt in 1925, shattering his hopes for an academic position. But what stands out here is the way Benjamin moves from an array of contemporary experiences of loss to the general claim that shared experience and its verbal correlative—the oral tale—have lost their relevance to social life, leaving us without a compass by which to navigate.

A loss of experience, then, to be mourned but also reflected upon. This contrasts strikingly with the tone Benjamin had used to discuss the word in an early text, "Experience," published in 1913, when he was a prominent figure in the Berlin branch of Gustav Wyneken's vitalistic youth movement. In this manifesto-like essay, Benjamin urges his readers to stick to their youthful openness and enthusiasm as opposed to grown-up (that is, world-weary) attempts at stifling them in the name of a supposedly superior experience, recourse to which is usually no more than "the mask of the adult." Hence, according to the young Benjamin, the need for a notion of experience that might open mankind to the fullness of the world, beyond the limitations imposed upon it by philistine adulthood and academic philosophy. These motives echo again in his 1915 essay "The Life of Students" and later in an unpublished piece, "On the Program of the Coming Philosophy," written in 1918.

Sometime in the early or mid-1920s, however, Benjamin abandons the rallying tone and starts to worry. Not in a conservative way, though: years later, in his 1933 essay "Experience and Poverty," he would recall the "mishmash" of revivalist styles and fashions trying to cover up the void left by the war and by the onset of a "monstrous development of technology." He seems to notice early on that the war had destroyed not only late-nineteenth-century bourgeois culture but also all other forms of social and intellectual life that were in its way, with results far removed from any sort of Nietzschean dawn he had yearned for in his student days.*

•

Benjamin's growing distance from his early intellectual commitments was accompanied by a growing distrust of authors, books, and literary genres that presumed to cope with the ongoing historical catastrophe without acknowledging the extent to which it had undermined the accumulated cultural experience they took for granted. A note of contempt can be discerned as early as 1917, in the essay "Dostoevsky's *The Idiot*," in which Benjamin tries to set the Russian writer apart from "the average novelist" who, in "the cheapest kind of novel," reduces protagonists to "marionettes," and sees everything through the lens of commonsense psychology, unable to envision character and destiny on a wider scale. Throughout the 1920s and early 1930s, Benjamin has no kind words to spare for what in 1936 he calls the "flood" of conventional war novels and war memoirs, and this discontent fueled a quest for other narrative models, either ante- or post-bourgeois, to help him understand and deal with the crisis of collective experience.

Benjamin's interest in alternative modes of storytelling led him in a number of different directions. He developed an interest in the fairy tale (*Märchen*) and even considered writing a whole book on this "form" he took to be untainted by "subjectivity" and "self-conscious individuality" (as he wrote to Gershom Scholem, May 20–25, 1925); the project never materialized, but some traces of it emerge in the final pages of "The Storyteller." Benjamin even went so far as to try his hand at the genre in "Mulberry Omelet" (1930), a superb tale on the Proustian theme of lost time.

Another pathway took Benjamin to the *Kalendergeschichten*, short prose tales meant for publication in popular almanacs, a genre that emerged in the seventeenth century. Its undisputed master is Johann Peter Hebel (1760–1826), a Lutheran vicar from southwestern Germany who composed scores of stories for the almanac of the Grand Duchy of Baden.[†] From 1926 to 1929, Benjamin wrote three polemical pieces on Hebel, denouncing his hijacking by conservative critics who presented him as a folk author, a herald of a small-town Germanness that they contrasted with modern rootless cosmopolitanism. Benjamin's Hebel cuts a completely different figure and is notable for complexity, not simplicity: He is a Christian but he also embodies the spirit of the Enlightenment, prizing ethics and tolerance

over mysticism and bigotry; he is a practical man of peasant stock, steeped in traditional wisdom, and yet he is no less of a contemplative soul, who can ponder both the stars and contemporary history; finally, he is a masterful storyteller, with an ear for his local dialect but no interest in the novel. It is hard to overestimate Hebel's importance for Benjamin and "The Storyteller." Hebel paved Benjamin's way to Leskov, whom he started to read seriously a bit later, as he tells Hugo von Hofmannsthal in a letter from February 1928; and it is more than likely that Hebel would have figured centrally in two unwritten essays, "Why the Art of Storytelling Is Dying Out" and "The Novelist and the Storyteller," which Benjamin mentions in his correspondence of 1928 and 1929. Hebel also influenced Benjamin's reading of his contemporary Oskar Maria Graf and provided him with a stylistic key to tune his voice in radio tales for children, like "The Lisbon Earthquake" (1931).

In these years, Benjamin is also keenly interested in contemporary novels that break away from the nineteenth-century mold. In his 1929 essay "The Image of Proust," for example, he has a lot to say about Proust's "text" or "work" and the novelty of a book that seems to dissolve the novel as we knew it; in the same year, in his essay on surrealism, Benjamin praises Louis Aragon's *Paris Peasant* (1926) and André Breton's *Nadja* (1928) for taking the novel into the city streets, "*seul champ d'expérience valable*," in Breton's famous formula. Finally, Benjamin's 1930 essay on *Berlin Alexanderplatz* brings him very close to "The Storyteller": Alfred Döblin's book, published in 1929, is an attempt to go beyond the novel and even beyond the written word, and it sets Benjamin to musing about the birth of a new form of epic poetry, archaic in its orality while thoroughly modern in its cinematic impetus.

•

It should be clear by now that Benjamin's thoughts on the dynamics and the demise of traditional experience and storytelling and his ideas on the nature and the fate of the novel are two sides of the same coin. This becomes particularly apparent when one reads the short story "The Handkerchief" (1932) and the essay "By the Fire" (1933) side by side, as a diptych. The first presents a fleeting vision of one of the central types in the world of oral narrative—the seafaring captain —while the second, ostensibly a review of

Arnold Bennett's *The Old Wives' Tale*, relates the novel as a genre to a very different foundational scene: the isolated individual brooding by the fireside. Taken together, they amount to a draft of a theory of the novel that echoes but also differs from Georg Lukács's own.[‡] Lukács's brilliant essay is built on the opposition between epic poetry and the novel—that is, a world where meaning is "immanent" to every act and a world abandoned by meaning and reduced to a fantasmatic persistence in the guise of convention. To Benjamin, on the contrary, the rise of the novel seems to be linked not so much to the inception of a metaphysical "dissonance" but rather to a breakup of tradition that leaves the individual—and the reader of novels—alone, deprived of "counsel" and left to his own resources in finding a meaning for his life. Hence the paradoxical structure of a typical novel, which is "not meant to be durable but to burn brightly" and thus to warm its solitary reader.

Benjamin's last stop before "The Storyteller" is "Experience and Poverty" (1933), where he wants us to "admit" that we are all at a loss and that our lack of social and human bearings amounts to "a completely new kind of poverty." If we are to move beyond it, we must first resist escapist fantasies and call this new poverty by its name: "barbarism." Of course, Benjamin knew perfectly well that this was a highly charged term in the year of Hitler's rise to power: Nazi propaganda had its own Spenglerian tune to play on the fall of bourgeois culture and the rise of a new, guilt-free barbarian age. Benjamin knowingly enters the lion's den to propose "a new, positive notion of barbarism" whose heroes are not Aryan purebloods but artists and scientists willing "to start fresh, to make do with little, to rebuild with next to nothing": Albert Einstein, Paul Klee, the Cubists, Bertolt Brecht, Paul Scheerbart, Adolf Loos, and Le Corbusier—the list even includes Walt Disney's Mickey Mouse. Benjamin is aware that the critical stakes of what he is proposing are high, but he probably also felt that going for less would be as good as irrelevant under the "shadow of the coming war."

•

A letter to Kitty Marx-Steinschneider, sent from Paris on April 15, 1936, allows us to peer over Benjamin's shoulder as he starts writing "The Storyteller," which he describes as

> a piece on the Russian author Leskov, a less known contemporary of Dostoevsky's. Do you know him? [. . .] Since I have no inclination to go into considerations on Russian literary history, I'll use the occasion to take an old hobby-horse out of the stable and try to apply to Leskov my old ideas on the opposition between novelist and storyteller, as well as to talk about my long-time preference for the latter.

"Experience that is passed from one mouth to the next is the source from which all storytellers have drawn," says Benjamin early on in the essay; as "experience's stock" falls in value, so the "living presence" of the traditional storyteller vanishes before our eyes. That "man of good counsel" could draw on his "capacious memory" to tell exemplary tales taken from age-old tradition, tales that contained not so much answers to practical or moral questions as suggestions on "how to continue a story"—that is, our own personal or collective stories. In this way, stories were woven into "the fabric of one's lived life." In the guise of wisdom, they then took root in the artisanal societies in which they flourished. The novel, on the other hand, "differs from all other types of prose." Its "stock-in-trade" is "the individual in his solitude" who cannot speak about his most urgent concerns in any exemplary way, "who has no one to counsel him and has no counsel to offer." Mirroring his characters' predicament, "the novelist has isolated himself" too, for his sort of narrative "neither comes from nor feeds into the oral tradition." Collective memory cedes to personal remembrance; the transformation of experience into tradition (to quote Benjamin's short note "On Proverbs") gives way to modern perplexity; instead of the "moral of the story," we must search for the "meaning of life."

So far, Benjamin is summing up or elaborating on ideas he had already noted elsewhere. But now comes an unexpected move, as he declares it would be "foolish" to consider the twilight of storytelling and the rise of the novel as "a 'symptom of decline' much less a 'modern' symptom." The whole process is rather to be understood as a "side effect of historical secular forces of productivity": industrial societies have no place or, more precisely, no use for the kind of wisdom contained in traditional tales. The novel is a response to this new state of affairs, but even this eminently modern genre risks loosing its foothold, as a new form of "communication"—"much more threatening than the novel"—sets in: "information." Information, whose first embodiment was journalism, forces

narrative to change gears. Exit the “chaste brevity,” the born storyteller’s reluctance to let explanation intrude into his tale; from now on, stories must be promptly verifiable and readily comprehensible if they are to find a place in the assembly-line temporality of accelerating industrial societies. (It would not be hard to extend this observation to postindustrial societies: it might suffice to substitute “data” for “stories.”)

On a hasty reading, much of this might sound like standard-issue Marxist discourse of the 1930s. Benjamin, however, bypasses any sort of orthodox Marxist talk about narrative as superstructure when he places it right next to work (artisanal or industrial), in the center of social life. Narrative is as essential and integral to the persistence of societies as other, only apparently more concrete, activities are. Social life-forms thus go hand in hand with the social life of forms. The heterodox originality of these ideas can be seen, for example, in the way Benjamin suggests we should try to understand the evolution of “epic forms” not in terms of schools, generations, or national histories but as happening in a rhythm “comparable to the rhythms of the geological transformations the earth’s surface has undergone over millennia.” Hence the tripartite scheme of storytelling—novel—information; hence, too, the striking similarities between the general argument of “The Storyteller” and that of Benjamin’s most ambitious theoretical text of the time, “The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction,” which he worked on at the same time.

Benjamin himself was very much aware of that, as can be seen in a letter he sent to Adorno from Paris on June 4, 1936: “I have recently written a piece on Nikolai Leskov which, without in the least aspiring to the theoretical scope of the one on art theory, nevertheless points to some parallels between the ‘fall of the aura’ and the fact that the art of storytelling is dying out.”

In both texts, Benjamin argues that landmark transformations of artistic forms can only be understood if studied in association with equally landmark changes in the deep domain of work and technology. Read in this light, Benjamin’s letter seems to suggest that what happens to narrative once it is cut off from experience is perfectly comparable to what happens to the work of art once it is cut loose from its crafted materiality, becomes an “image,” and starts to circulate much in the way money does. Read with hindsight, this is strikingly prescient: Benjamin points a finger toward our own time, in which—in another reversal of fate, though now a dismal one

—storytelling and narrative have become key, cant terms in the vocabulary of corporate branding and political propaganda, the better to keep us from realizing that these are just the things of which modern life, with its flows of information and omnipresent algorithms, is bereft.

•

"The Storyteller" shows Benjamin the critic at his seismographic best. Not only that: here, as in his essays on Proust, Kafka, Baudelaire, or nineteenth-century Paris (in which, by the way, a leading motif is again the dissolution of experience, *Erfahrung*, into sensation, *Erlebnis*), Benjamin is also at his literary best. Never flat or pedantic, his prose is all at once precise and musical, compact and evocative—as the reader may now judge from Tess Lewis's superb, subtle translation. Benjamin's writing at this moment in his career is also remarkable in the way it weaves a narrative element into critical discourse: many essays contain anecdotes, exemplary scenes, or parable-like stories. An example of just how this works and what it shows about how Benjamin worked as a writer may serve as a coda to this introduction.

In the seventh section of "The Storyteller," where Benjamin sets out to show how stories thrive when left unexplained, he turns to an episode from *The Histories* of Herodotus. Defeated by the Persian emperor Cambyses, poor Psammenitus, "the last Egyptian pharaoh," is forced to look on as his daughter is taken into captivity and his son is led to execution. But Psammenitus does not weep. It is only the sight of one of his former attendants that makes him beat his forehead with grief. Why? Herodotus does not tell us—or so Benjamin says—and in this lack of explanation lies the reason why this story "does not use itself up" the way information does but preserves its "germinative power."

The problem is that Herodotus does offer an explanation for Psammenitus's behavior, as can be seen in the relevant passage of *The Histories* printed at the end of this volume. Of course, Benjamin may have forgotten this detail—a rather crucial one. But then it is not clear that Benjamin actually read the story of Psammenitus in Herodotus. His source may have been Montaigne's essay "On Sadness"; he certainly read it in Ernst Bloch's "Silence and Mirror," one of the short pieces collected in *Traces* (1930)[§]; or maybe he stumbled upon it in Jean Paulhan's article

“Carnet du Spectateur” in the November 1928 issue of the *Nouvelle Revue Française*. There Paulhan tells the story of Psammenitus and quotes his friend René-Martin Guelliot’s reaction to it (“If Psammenitus lived in our times, newspapers would say he liked his servants better than his children”).‖ Paulhan’s piece may also have inspired Benjamin to tell the story to his lover Asja Lacis and his friend Franz Hessel, asking them for their interpretations, which Benjamin then proceeded to quote (along with Guelliot), first in his short piece “The Art of Storytelling” from 1933 and then in the seventh section of “The Storyteller.”¶

This tiny example shows us Benjamin at work: collecting bits and pieces everywhere in the course of his vast readings and travels, and stitching them together into text that may be compared to the embroideries of his contemporary Marie Monnier, always careful not to hide the mixed and sometimes fragmentary nature of what goes into his work, and terribly conscious that the very web of life seems to be “unraveling on all sides after having been woven thousands of years ago.”** In this way, and against the odds of the times, Benjamin the essayist is like a quirky, modern-day descendant of the craftsmen he celebrates in “The Storyteller.”

—SAMUEL TITAN

*For a fuller survey of the question, see Martin Jay, *Songs of Experience* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2005), chapter 8: “Lamenting the Crisis of Experience: Benjamin and Adorno”; the question is also discussed in many passages of Howard Eiland and Michael W. Jennings’s recent, reliable biography, *Walter Benjamin: A Critical Life* (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press, 2014).

† Since Hebel is far from being a familiar author in the English-speaking world, it seemed useful to include three stories from his collection *The Treasure Chest of the Rhenish Family Friend* in this volume: “Unexpected Reunion,” “Kannitverstan,” and “How Firebrand Freddy Escaped from Prison One Day and Safely Crossed the Border.”

‡ Lukács’s *Theory of the Novel* (1916) was very much in Benjamin’s mind as he wrote the Bennett review—see his letters to Gershom Scholem, May

7, 1933, and to Siegfried Kracauer, December 10, 1934.

§In “The Storyteller,” Benjamin also quotes extensively from a 1935 essay by Bloch, “The Giant’s Toy as Legend,” printed here as well.

‖Paulhan’s 1925 book on proverbs, *Expérience du proverbe*, is an important source for what Benjamin has to say on the subject.

¶As recorded in the undated manuscript notes under the title “Material on Psammenitus,” reproduced in the first Suhrkamp edition of Benjamin’s *Gesammelte Schriften*, volume IV.2, pages 1011–12; the same notes refer to Paulhan’s 1928 article.

** Marie Monnier was the sister of Adrienne Monnier, the avant-garde librarian at whose shop on the rue de l’Odéon a show of Marie’s embroideries was held in 1924; Valéry wrote a text for the catalog, from which Benjamin quotes in a key moment of his 1936 essay.

THE STORYTELLER ESSAYS

JOHANN PETER HEBEL

PERHAPS, ladies and gentlemen, you have had the experience while reading the newspaper of being brought up short by a particularly striking or outrageous item, the report of a fire, say, or a sordid crime. And if you then tried to picture the event *in greater detail*, you would without a doubt have undertaken something very strange whether you were aware of it or not. You would, namely, have created a kind of photomontage by unconsciously integrating into the setting hovering in your mind—the incident may have occurred in Goldap or in Tilsit, a city you do not know at all—elements from a setting entirely familiar to you and a very specific one at that, that is, not Frankfurt in general, but your very home or parlor in Frankfurt. Home or parlor, which suddenly seemed to have been transported to Tilsit or Goldap. But in fact, the very opposite occurred: Tilsit or Goldap was transported to your parlor. And you went yet a step further. Once you had found the "here," you proceeded to establish the "now." The news item may have been dated September 11, but you did not read it until the 15th. However, if you had wished to grasp and to experience the affair, you would not have projected yourself back four days but instead would have thought: this is occurring right now, at this very moment and in my parlor. You have suddenly endowed the random, abstract, sensational event with a "here and now." You have made it concrete, and there is no telling where this might lead you.

The effect would be even more unpredictable, however, if such evidence of the here and now could be furnished to significant and momentous events rather than merely to random sensational news stories. All the more so if the "now" were historically significant and the "here" were flourishing and complete! If we imagine all these premises as perfectly realized, we have the prose of Johann Peter Hebel. All engagement with this great and still underappreciated master consists in making vividly present this man who has no equal in his ability to make things vividly present for us. He is a vivid presenter, to be sure, not only of tales of robbers, of family dramas, of shipwrecks, or stories of the Wild West (although of these too), but also of the highest powers of his region and his time. This is to say that these very modest and simple works (perfect examples according to philologists of "folk art," by which they really mean the literature of the poor), that these

works, I maintain, thanks to thousands of tiny, invisible wings, keep themselves aloft over a great abyss, the abyss that yawned between Hebel's time and the region in which he lived. A contemporary of the great French Revolution who was most decisively and radically struck by the great thinkers of the time, he nevertheless remained a southern German provincial, a retiring bachelor and court deacon to the Grand Duke of Baden, not only obliged to live in extremely straitened circumstances, but even forced to embrace his modest position. That Hebel was incapable of saying or thinking weighty, important things any other way than figuratively is one of the strengths of his stories, and underlay what aimlessness and weakness there was in his life. Indeed, the almanac stories of the *Rhenish Family Friend* were written out of his extreme constraint, about which he often grumbled. This did not prevent him, however, from keeping his sense of proportion, and even if he never managed to express things great and small in any other way than deeply interwoven and intertwined with each other, his realism was always strong enough to protect him from the mysticism of the petty and the small, a mysticism to which Stifter occasionally succumbed.

What saved Hebel from this mysticism was precisely his theological training. It is evident throughout his oeuvre, which is thoroughly edifying, yet has a worldly and intellectual breadth almost without compare since the end of the Middle Ages. For what is it that edifies Hebel? The Enlightenment and the great Revolution. Not their so-called ideas, but their situations and their social types, the cosmopolitan, the enlightened abbé, the ruffian, and the philanthropist. The way theological and cosmopolitan stances are fused in his writing is the secret to the incomparable concretion at the heart of his work. His characters' present, for example, is not simply that of 1760 to 1826 (the years of his own life); the era in which they live has no date. Indeed, because theology measures history in generations, Hebel, too, sees in the actions of his little people the struggles of generations through all the crises unleashed by the Revolution of '89. The lives and deaths of entire generations beat in the rhythm of the sentences in the story "Unexpected Reunion" that cover a span of fifty years during which a fiancée mourns her beloved, who perished in a mining accident.

> In the meantime, the city of Lisbon in Portugal was destroyed by an earthquake, and the Seven Years' War came to an end, and Emperor

> Francis I died, and the Jesuit order was dissolved, and Poland was partitioned, and Empress Maria Theresa died, and Streunsee was executed, America was liberated, and the combined French and Spanish forces could not capture Gibraltar. The Turks imprisoned General Stein in the Veterani Cave in Hungary, and Emperor Joseph died too. King Gustav of Sweden conquered Russian Finland, and the French Revolution and the long war began, and Emperor Leopold II went to his grave as well. Napoleon conquered Prussia, and the English bombarded Copenhagen, and the farmers sowed and reaped. The millers milled, and the blacksmiths hammered, and the miners dug for metal seams in their workshop under the ground. Yet in the year 1809, when the miners of Falun . . .

When Hebel depicts the passing of fifty years of mourning this way, it almost becomes a lament, but a lament for the way of the world similar to those sometimes found in the opening pages of medieval chronicles. For we do not encounter the attitude of a historian in these lines, but that of a chronicler. The historian limits himself to "world history," the chronicler recounts the way of the world. The former is concerned with the web of events woven from incalculable threads of cause and effect—and all that he has studied or learned is but a tiny nodal point in this net; the latter is concerned with the minor events, narrowly circumscribed, of his town or region—but for him this is not a fragment or a mere element of the universal, it is rather something other and more. Because in writing his chronicle, the true chronicler also writes a parable of the way of the world. What the town's local history and the way of the world reflect is the old rapport between the microcosm and macrocosm.

When Hebel begins one of his stories with: "As everyone knows, an old bailiff from Wasselnheim complained to his wife that his French had almost cost him his life," we hear in that simple opening "as everyone knows" an ironic echo of all the correspondences between the way of the world and local gossip. Just as ironic and just as far removed from any provincial smugness is the narrowness of his Baden settings, because the horizons of Hebel's terrestrial globe, in the center of which lie Segringen, Brassenheim, and Tuttlingen, are marked by Moscow and Amsterdam, Jerusalem, and Milan. So it is with all authentic, spontaneous folk art: it speaks of the exotic and the monstrous with the same affection and in the same language

as it does of its local subjects. Hence the powerful “here” of his stories’ settings. The wide-open, observant gaze of this parson and philanthropist integrates the edifice of the world with village economics, and he treats the planets, moons, and comets as a chronicler, not as a schoolteacher. And so, for instance, we read of the moon (which suddenly appears like a landscape just as it does in one of Chagall’s famous paintings): “One day there lasts about as long as two of our weeks and a night lasts equally as long, so a night watchman must take care not to lose count when the clock strikes 223 or 309.”

It is not hard to guess, after reading sentences like these, that Jean Paul was this man’s favorite writer. Such men, whom Goethe called delicate empiricists—because to them everything factual was already theory and the anecdotal, the criminal, the comical, and the local fact, in particular, a moral theorem—had, of course, a capricious, absurd, and unpredictable connection to the entire breadth of reality. *In Levana; or, the Doctrine of Education*, Jean Paul recommended feeding brandy to infants and insisted they be given beer. Much less controversially, Hebel filled his almanac tales with crimes, villainy, and pranks. And yet, at the same time, his scoundrels and rascals recall Voltaire, Condorcet, and Diderot, and the unspeakably sordid shrewdness of his Jews has as little connection to the Talmud as to the spirit of Moses Hess, the somewhat later precursor of the socialists. Hebel drew on older sources for many of his scoundrel’s tales, but the trickster and vagabond temperaments of Firebrand Freddy and his brother Henry and of Red Dieter were Hebel’s own. He was notorious for his pranks as a boy, and of the adult Hebel we are told that when Gall, the renowned pioneer of phrenology, once came to Baden, Hebel was introduced to him. Gall was asked his opinion but his only pronouncement after mumbling unintelligibly while feeling Hebel’s head were the words “unusually well-developed.” In reply Hebel asked, “You mean my thieves’ bump?”

No one had a keener sense of the demonic element in Hebel’s tricksters than Dambacher, who illustrated an edition of the *Comic Tales of the Rhenish Family Friend* with lithographs in 1842. These unusually powerful illustrations are, so to speak, secret signs along the smugglers’ hidden paths on which Hebel’s sunnier scoundrels consort with the dismal and frightening petty bourgeoisie from Büchner’s *Wozzeck*. For this pastor, who understood better than any other German writer how to represent commerce

and to play on the entire scale of registers from the basest haggling to the most lavish generosity, was not one to overlook the demonic element in bourgeois business life. He may have associated with the best representatives of the dominant class, with the most solid businessmen of the petty bourgeoisie, and that is precisely why he had wanted to teach them the proper, the only method of accounting that brings happiness. Double-entry bookkeeping that always adds up. Under assets: the daily life of the peasant and the bourgeois, the possession of interest-bearing minutes, paid-up capital of labor or ruse. Under liabilities: morality. Business morals, personal morals, the morals of the general and the head of the family, of the burglar and the burgled, of the victor and the vanquished. No situation is so hopeless or abject that virtue would refuse to take root, but it cannot dispense with disguises. That is why the moral never appears where convention would have it. Everyone knows how the barber's boy in Segringen agreed to trim the beard of the "stranger from the army" because no one else had the courage after the soldier said, "If you cut me, I'll stab you to death." To which the boy answered in the end, "But, Sir, you'd never have stabbed me because if you'd flinched and I nicked your face, I'd have gotten you first. I'd have slashed your throat on the spot, jumped up and run off as quick as a flash." Such are Hebel's stories. They all have false bottoms. If murder and manslaughter, thieving and cursing are on top, patience, prudence, and humanity lie below.

For Hebel, the moral, an alien element to the mediocre writer, is a continuation of the epic by other means. And when he reduces ethos to a question of tact, the concretion at the heart of his work is most energetic. The here and now of virtue is not an abstract action dictated by maxims but is guided by presence of mind. Those actions are moral—such would have been Hebel's definition—whose maxims are hidden. Not stashed away like a thief's loot, but concealed like gold in the ground. His morality is thus tied to the circumstances in which people first discover it. And as such it is like piety, which can never be abstract, but divides all of life into situations that serve it. The votive paintings in Bavarian or southern Italian churches are full of critical situations that have indelibly marked the spirits of the pious. Worldly suffering and danger below, the Madonna enthroned in the clouds above. So it is in Hebel. Below, if you will, is the arena of the homemade, of things done according to the rules, the clear and the just. Up above, however, we can see the deity of the French Revolution hovering

supernaturally, like the Madonna, near the ceiling. And that is why Hebel's stories are imperishable. They are the votive paintings the Enlightenment offered up to the goddess of Reason.

1929

THE CRISIS OF THE NOVEL

On Döblin's Berlin Alexanderplatz

EXISTENCE, for the epic, is an ocean. There is nothing more epic than the ocean. One can react to the ocean in very different ways, of course. One can, for example, lie on the beach, listen to the surf, and collect shells washed up by the waves. That is what the epic poet does. One can also sail the ocean—for many reasons or for none at all. One can sail out to sea and cruise on the open water with no land in sight, just waves and sky. That is what the novelist does. He is the truly solitary, silent individual. The epic man merely rests. In epics, the people rest after a day's work; they listen, dream, and collect. The novelist has isolated himself from the people and their activities. The birthplace of the novel is the individual in his solitude who is no longer able to speak about his most important concerns in an exemplary way, who has no one to counsel him and has no counsel to offer. Writing a novel means taking to an extreme the incommensurable in the depiction of human existence. What distinguishes the novel from the genuine epic becomes clear when one thinks of Homer's works or of Dante's. What can be passed on orally, the epic's assets, is altogether different from what constitutes the novel's stock-in-trade. The novel differs from all other types of prose—folktales, legends, proverbs, comical stories—in that it neither comes from nor feeds into the oral tradition. This distinguishes it above all from storytelling, which is the type of prose that represents the epic at its purest. Indeed, nothing contributes more to the dangerous silencing of the inner self, nothing kills the spirit of storytelling as thoroughly as the outrageous proportion the reading of novels has attained in all our lives. Thus it is the voice of a born storyteller we hear opposing the novelist when we read: "Nor will I speak of the fact that I consider it useful . . . to liberate the epic from the book, useful above all with regard to language. The book is the death of real language. The most vital creative forces of language escape the epic poet who only writes." Flaubert would never have spoken like this. This thesis is Döblin's. He wrote an extended account of it for the first volume of the annals of the Section for Literature of the Prussian Academy of the Arts. His "Structure of the Epic Work" is a masterful study of the crisis of the novel that begins with the rehabilitation of the epic that we see all around us, even in the

theater. Those who consider Döblin's lecture carefully will no longer need to stop at the external evidence of this crisis, of this forceful return of the radical epic, and the flood tide of biographical and historical novels will no longer astonish them. Far from resigning himself to this crisis, Döblin the theoretician anticipates it and adopts its cause as his own. His latest book demonstrates that his theoretical thinking and his creative practice coincide.

Nothing is more instructive than comparing Döblin's stance with that of André Gide in his recently published *Journal of the Counterfeiters*, an attitude that is equally sovereign, equally courageous in practice, equally precise, and yet fundamentally opposed to Döblin's in every respect. The epic's current situation finds its sharpest expression in the opposition between these two critical intelligences. In the autobiographical commentary on his latest novel, Gide develops his doctrine of the *roman pur*. With the greatest subtlety imaginable he sets out to eliminate all straightforward, linear narration (all the primary characteristics of the epic) for the sake of ingenious, purely novelistic (which in this case also means Romantic) devices. The character's attitude toward the action, the writer's attitude toward his characters and his technique should all become part of the novel itself. In short, the *roman pur* is sheer interiority; it admits no exteriority, and as such it is the polar opposite of the purely epic stance, which is that of storytelling. Gide's ideal novel is—in complete contrast to Döblin's—the novel of pure writing. He is perhaps the last to uphold Flaubert's stance. It is, therefore, no surprise to find the sharpest rebuke to this approach in Döblin's lecture. "You will throw your hands up in horror when I advise authors to be resolutely lyrical, dramatic, even reflexive in epic writing. But I insist on it."

The bafflement of certain readers of this new book shows how boldly Döblin pursues this approach. Now, it is certainly true that few books have been narrated in this way; rarely has the reader's comfort been rocked by such waves of events and reflection, never has the spray of speech as it is actually spoken so drenched the reader to the bone. But we need not resort to technical terms, speak of *dialogue intérieur*, or refer to James Joyce. In fact, this is something altogether different. This book's guiding stylistic principle is the montage. There is a blizzard of petty bourgeois publications, tales of scandal and misfortune, sensational events of 1928, folk songs, and classified ads in this narrative. The montage explodes the novel structurally as well as stylistically and opens up new, epic possibilities, especially

formal ones. The material of the montage is far from arbitrary. True montage is based on the document. In its fanatical battle against the work of art, Dadaism made itself an ally of daily life through montage. It was the first to proclaim, even if rather uncertainly, the absolute power of the authentic. In its best moments, film attempted to habituate us to montage. Here, for the first time, it has been placed at the service of epic literature. It is biblical verses, statistics, and song lyrics that Döblin uses to give authority to the epic narrative. They correspond to the formulaic verses of ancient epics.

This montage is so dense the author has trouble getting a word in. He has reserved the chapter headings, in the style of street ballads, for himself; otherwise, he's in no hurry to make himself heard. (Yet he will eventually have his say.) It is astonishing how long he follows his characters before he risks confronting them. He approaches things gently, as an epic writer should. Whatever happens, even what occurs very suddenly, seems to have been prepared well in advance. The Berlin dialect itself has inspired him in his measured approach. It moves in a gentle tempo. For Berliners speak as connoisseurs and with great love for the way they speak. They relish their dialect. They take their time when cursing, mocking, or threatening, just as they do over breakfast. Glassbrenner gave Berlinish a dramatic flair. In this book, its epic depths are sounded; the ship of Franz Biberkopf's life is heavily laden, but it never runs aground. This book is a monument to the Berlin dialect because the narrator is not interested in touting the city's regional charms to win the reader over. He speaks from the heart of the city. Berlin is his megaphone. Its dialect is one of the powers turned against the closed-off character of the old novel. For this book is not at all closed off. It has its own morality, one that is relevant even to Berliners. (Tieck's *Abraham Tonelli* had already let loose with Berlin slang, but no one has yet dared cure it.)

It is worth looking at the cure to which Franz Biberkopf is subjected. What happens to him? But first, why is the book called *Berlin Alexanderplatz* with *The Story of Franz Biberkopf* relegated to a subtitle? What is Alexanderplatz in Berlin? It is the place where the most violent changes have been taking place for the past two years, where excavators and pile drivers operate nonstop, where the ground trembles from their blows and from columns of buses and subway cars, where the intestines of the metropolis and the inner courtyards surrounding the Georgenkirchplatz

have been exposed more deeply than anywhere else, and where neighborhoods from the 1890s have survived unchanged more quietly than anywhere else in the untouched labyrinths around Marsiliusstrasse (where the secretaries of the immigration police are stabled in a tenement house) and around Kaiserstrasse (where the whores make their nightly rounds). This is no industrial district; but mostly of commerce; of the petty bourgeoisie. And then there is its sociological negative: crooks recruited from the ranks of the unemployed. Franz Biberkopf is one. He gets out of Tegel Prison without a job, manages to remain respectable for a while, starts hawking things on a few street corners, lets that drop, and joins the Pums gang. The radius of his existence extends no farther than a thousand meters from Alexanderplatz. The square rules his life. A cruel regent if you will. An absolute ruler. For the reader forgets all else and begins to experience life in this limited space and to realize how little he had known it. It is all very different from what the reader imagined when he took this book down from the mahogany bookcase. It has no hint at all of a “social novel.” No one in this book sleeps under the stars. Everyone always has a room. None of the characters are ever seen searching for a place to stay. Even the first of the month seems to have lost its menace around Alexanderplatz. These people are wretched, to be sure. Nevertheless they live in wretchedness in their own rooms. How is that? How could that be?

There are two factors. One large and one rather limited. The large one: wretchedness is not, in fact, the way little Moritz imagined it. Real wretchedness, at least, rather than the one we dread. Men are not the only ones who must live according to their means; poverty and affliction must make do with what they have and struggle to make ends meet. Their agents, love and alcohol, are also occasionally rebellious. Nothing is so grim that we cannot bear it for a time. In this book wretchedness shows its jovial side. It sits down at the same table with people, but that does not stop their conversation; everyone pulls up their chairs and continues their meal. This is a truth that the new low-rent Naturalism refuses to acknowledge. That is why it took a great storyteller to do it justice. It is said that Lenin hated only one thing more than misery itself: accommodating oneself to it. That, too, is a bourgeois attitude, not only in its petty, tight-fisted slovenliness, but also in its greater wisdom. In this sense, Döblin’s story is bourgeois, and is so in a much more constricting way than by tendency or intention, that is, in accordance with its origins. What emerges anew here, enthralling as ever,

and with undiminished force is Charles Dickens's great magic, in which the bourgeois and the criminal so magnificently play the same game because they both have their interests (opposed as they are) in one and the same world. The universe of these crooks is identical to that of the bourgeoisie. Franz Biberkopf's progression from pimp to petty bourgeois merely follows a heroic metamorphosis of bourgeois consciousness.

The novel, one could say in response to the theory of the *roman pur*, is like the ocean. Salt is its only source of purity. What, then, is this book's salt? Epic salt serves the same function as mineral salt: it makes those things it binds with durable. And duration is a characteristic of the epic in a completely different way than it is for other works of literature. Duration not in time, but in the reader. The true reader reads an epic in order to "retain" it. And the reader certainly retains two things from this book: the story of the arm and the incident with Mieze. How does Franz Biberkopf end up getting thrown under a car and losing his arm? And having his girlfriend taken from him and murdered? We are told on the second page. "Because he demands more from life than bread and butter." In this case not rich food, money, or women but something much worse. What his big mouth hungers for is much vaguer. A hunger for destiny is eating away at him, that's what it is. This man is always tempting fate; no wonder it comes after him. How his hunger for destiny is stilled, stilled for good, and room is made for the simple satisfaction of bread and butter, how the crook becomes wise: this is the course of events. In the end, Franz Biberkopf is left without fate; he becomes "*helle*," or clearheaded, as Berliners would say. With consummate mastery, Döblin has made his Franz's maturation unforgettable. Just as Jews reveal a child's secret second name at his bar mitzvah, so too does Döblin give Biberkopf a second name. He is now called Franz Karl. Yet at the same time, something very strange has happened to this Franz Karl, assistant doorman in a factory. Even though Döblin keeps a sharp eye on his hero, we cannot be sure that this has not escaped his attention. Namely, from this point on, Franz Biberkopf is no longer an exemplary figure, but has been transported, still living, to the heaven of fictional characters. Hope and memory will console him in the heaven of his small doorman's lodge for his failure in life. As for us, we will not continue to spy on him in his lodge. That is, after all, the law of the novel: as soon as the hero helps himself, his existence is no longer any help to us. If this truth is revealed at its grandest and most pitiless form in

Flaubert's *Sentimental Education*, Franz Biberkopf's story is the "sentimental education" of the crook. It is the most extreme, vertiginous, final, and most advanced stage of the old bourgeois bildungsroman.

1930

MULBERRY OMELET

I RECOUNT this old tale for those who would like to try figs or Falernian wine, borscht or a peasant lunch on Capri. There once was a king who had all the power and treasures of the world at his command, but who was nonetheless unhappy and became more melancholy with each passing year. One day he summoned his personal cook and said to him: “You have served me faithfully for many a year and filled my table with the most magnificent dishes. I am well-disposed toward you. Now, however, I would like to put your art to a final test. You must make me a mulberry omelet such as I enjoyed fifty years ago in my earliest childhood. My father, at the time, was waging war against his evil neighbor to the east. He conquered us and we had to escape. And so we fled day and night, my father and I, until we reached a dark wood. We wandered through it and were on the brink of perishing from hunger and exhaustion when we stumbled on a little hut. In it lived an old woman who most warmly bid us rest and set to work at the stove. It wasn’t long before the mulberry omelet appeared before us. The moment I took the first bite, I felt a wonderful sense of consolation and my heart swelled with hope. I was a mere child then and I did not think of the relief this delicious food provided. But when I later had the woman searched for throughout my entire realm, neither she nor anyone able to prepare a mulberry omelet could be found. If you can grant me this last wish, I will make you my son-in-law and heir to my throne. But if you cannot satisfy me, you must die.” The cook replied: “Your majesty, you must then summon the hangman at once. I know well the secret of the mulberry omelet and all its ingredients, from the common cress to the noble thyme. I know well the spell one must say as one stirs and how the boxwood whisk must always be turned towards the right lest our labor be rewarded only with trouble. But nevertheless, oh King, I must die. Nevertheless my omelet will not satisfy you. For how shall I season it with all that you savored at the time: the danger of battle and the alertness of the pursued, the warmth of the hearth, and the sweetness of rest, the foreign present, and the dark future?” Thus spoke the cook. The king remained silent for a time and not long after, he released the cook from his duty richly rewarded.

1930

THE LISBON EARTHQUAKE

HAVE YOU ever had to wait for a prescription at the pharmacy, and watched it being made? Gram by gram or decigram by decigram, the pharmacist weighs out all the substances and powders needed for the finished medicine on a scale with very delicate weights. I feel like a pharmacist when I tell you stories in my radio broadcast. My weights are the minutes, and I have to weigh them with great precision, so many of these, so many of those, to get the balance right. “Why is that?” you’ll ask. “If you want to tell us about the Lisbon earthquake, start with the beginning, then tell us what happened next.” But if I do it that way, I doubt you’ll find it very amusing. One house collapses after another, one family perishes after another. The terror that spreads with the engulfing flames and flooding water; the darkness, the pillaging and the cries of the injured, and the wails of those looking for their family members—hearing this and only this would not have any appeal. And these things are more or less the same in any great natural disaster.

The earthquake that destroyed Lisbon on November 1, 1775, was not simply a disaster like a thousand others, but was unique and remarkable in many respects. And how it was different is what I would like to tell you. First, it was one of the strongest, most destructive earthquakes that has ever occurred. But that’s not the only reason it caught and held the entire world’s attention as few events did that century. The destruction of Lisbon at the time would be comparable to the destruction of Chicago or London today. In the mid-eighteenth century, Portugal was at the height of its colonial power. Lisbon was one of the wealthiest trading cities in the world; its port at the mouth of the Tagus River was filled with ships year in, year out, and encircled by the headquarters of the most important trading companies of England, France, the German states, and especially Hamburg. There were 30,000 houses in Lisbon and its population numbered well over 250,000, about a quarter of whom lost their lives in the earthquake. The king’s court was renowned for its strictness as well as its splendor, and the many descriptions of Lisbon published in the years before the earthquake contain the most peculiar accounts of the rigid ceremoniousness with which the courtiers and their families gathered in their coaches on summer evenings in the Rossio, the city’s main square, and chatted for a time without stepping down from their carriages. The general conception of the King of Portugal

was so exalted, one of the many flyers that spread detailed accounts of the catastrophe throughout Europe could not comprehend the fact that such a great king was also affected by it. “Just as the extent of a disaster can only be grasped once it has been overcome,” this curious reporter wrote, “so will everyone be best able to picture the dreadful situation caused by this terrible event in considering the fact that a great king and his wife, abandoned by all and sundry, were forced to spend the entire day in a carriage in a miserable state.” The flyers in which such reports can be read served as newspapers at the time. Those who could, gathered as detailed and precise eyewitness accounts as possible, then printed them up and sold them. Later, I will read to you from one such report, based on the experiences of an Englishman living in Lisbon at the time.

There is another particular reason why this event moved people so deeply and why countless flyers about it were passed from hand to hand and new ones even continued to appear almost a hundred years later. The effects of this earthquake were the most extensive ever recorded. They were felt across Europe, even as far away as Africa, and it has been calculated that its most distant tremors spanned the enormous surface area of two and a half million square kilometers. Its strongest tremors extended from the coast of Morocco on the one side to the coasts of Andalusia and France on the other. The cities of Cádiz, Jerez, and Algeciras were almost completely destroyed. According to one eyewitness, the towers of the cathedral in Seville trembled like reeds in the wind. Still, the most powerful shocks spread through the sea. Powerful waves were felt from Finland to the Dutch East Indies, and it was calculated that the shocks spread with unbelievable speed through the ocean, traveling from the coast of Portugal to the mouth of the Elbe in just a quarter of an hour. So much for what was experienced at the time of the disaster. What caught people’s imagination even more at the time were the strange natural phenomena observed in the weeks preceding the earthquake. These phenomena were later interpreted, and not always without justification, as omens of the future calamity. Two weeks before the fatal day, in Locarno, in southern Switzerland, steam had suddenly started spewing out of the earth and turned within two hours into a red haze, which fell to earth in the evening as purple rain. From that time on, people reported terrible hurricanes, downpours, and flooding throughout western Europe. Eight days before the quake, the ground near Cádiz was covered with masses of worms that had crawled out of the earth.

No one was more preoccupied with these strange events than the great German philosopher Kant, whose name some of you may have heard before. At the time of the earthquake, he was a young man of twenty-four. Although he never left his hometown of Königsberg either before or after, he zealously collected every account of the earthquake he could find, and the short study he wrote about it formed, no doubt, the beginnings of scientific geography in Germany. Certainly the beginnings of seismology. I would gladly tell you about the path this science followed from that account of the 1755 earthquake until today. But I must be careful not to let our Englishman, whose experiences in the earthquake I would like to read to you, get lost in the crowd. He is waiting impatiently to have his say after 150 years, during which no one paid him any attention, and so will allow me only a few words about what we know of earthquakes today. Keep in mind: it's not the way you imagine it. I wager that if I were to pause briefly and ask you how you would explain an earthquake, the first thing you would think of is a volcano. Volcanic eruptions are, indeed, often associated with earthquakes or are, at least, announced by them. For two thousand years, from the ancient Greeks to Kant and even later, until about 1870, people believed that earthquakes were caused by fiery gases, steam in the earth's core and similar things. But when people began to study the matter, taking measurements and making calculations with instruments more precise and finely calibrated than you can possibly imagine—which I, myself, can also scarcely imagine—in short, when they began to systematically research earthquakes, the results were completely different, at least for those of greatest magnitude like the one in Lisbon. They do not come from the earth's innermost core, which is still thought of as being liquid, or rather, mud-like, a kind of fiery sludge, but from movements in the earth's crust. The earth's crust is a layer about three thousand kilometers thick. This layer is always in motion; the masses in this layer are constantly pushing against each other and trying to come to equilibrium. Some of the causes that upset this equilibrium are known; others are being explored through incessant research. This much is clear: the most significant changes are due to the constant cooling of the earth. This creates enormous tensions in the rock masses, which ultimately break apart and shift into a new configuration in search of a new equilibrium, a process we experience as earthquakes. Other changes are due to the erosion of the mountains, which become lighter, and alluvial deposits on the seabed, which becomes heavier.

Storms that rage around the world, especially in autumn, wreak destruction on the earth's surface. And finally, we are in the process of discovering what forces are exerted on the globe's surface through the gravitational pull of other planets. "But," you might say, "if that's true, then the earth will actually never be stable—there will always be earthquakes." And you're right. That's how it is. The extremely sensitive instruments we now have for measuring tremors—we have thirteen earthquake-monitoring stations in various cities in Germany alone—are never completely still. This means that the earth is always trembling, but mostly so lightly that we don't notice anything.

All the worse, then, when we suddenly feel the earth shaking out of the blue. The expression "out of the blue" can be understood quite literally. "The sun shone out in its full lustre," wrote the Englishman who will now finally have his say.

> [T]he whole face of the sky was perfectly serene and clear, and not the least signal or warning of that approaching event . . . It was on the morning of this fatal day, between the hours of nine and ten, that I was set down in my apartment, just finishing a letter, when the papers and the table I was writing on began to tremble with a gentle motion, which rather surprised me, as I could not perceive a breath of wind stirring. Whilst I was reflecting with myself what this could be owing to . . . , the whole house began to shake from the very foundation . . . [There sounded] a strange frightful kind of noise underground, resembling the hollow distant rumbling of thunder . . . Upon this I threw down my pen, and started upon my feet, remaining a moment in suspense, whether I should stay in the apartment or run into the street, as the danger in both places seemed equal; and still flatter[ed] myself that this tremor might produce no other effects . . . ; but in a moment I was roused from my dream, being instantly stunned with a most horrid crash, as if every edifice in the city had tumbled down at once. The house I was in shook with such violence, that the upper stories immediately fell; and though my apartment (which was the first floor) did not then share the same fate, yet everything was thrown out of its place . . . I . . . expected nothing less than to be soon crushed to death, as the walls continued rocking to and fro in the fright-fulest manner, opening in several places; large stones falling down on every side from

> the cracks, and the ends of most of the rafters starting out from the roof . . . [T]he sky in a moment became so gloomy that I could now distinguish no particular object; it was an Egyptian darkness indeed, . . . owing, no doubt, to the prodigious clouds of dust and lime raised from so violent a concussion, and, as some reported, to sulphureous exhalations . . . [At last the] gloom began to disperse and the violence of the shock seemed pretty much abated . . .
>
> I shall always look upon it as a particular providence that I happened on this occasion to be undressed; for had I dressed myself . . .when I got out of bed, . . . I should, in all probability, have run into the street at the beginning of the shock, . . . and, consequently, have had my brains dashed out . . . I . . . put on a pair of shoes and a coat [and] proceeded on as fast as I conveniently could, though with the utmost caution, and . . . found myself safe and unhurt in the large open space before St. Paul's church . . . Here I stood some time, and observed the ships tumbling and tossing about as in a violent storm; . . . [and] the fine new quay, built entirely of rough marble, at an immense expense, was entirely swallowed up, with all the people on it, who had fled thither for safety, . . . and at the same time everyone of the boats and vessels that were near it were drawn into the cavity . . .

From other reports, we know that approximately an hour after the second and most devastating earthquake, the monstrous twenty-meter-high wave that the Englishman saw from a distance washed over the city. When the tide retreated, the bed of the Tagus appeared, completely dry. The wave's recoil was so powerful, it sucked all the water from the river with it. "As soon as it grew dark," the Englishman concluded,

> the whole city appeared in a blaze, which was so bright that I could easily see to read by it. It may be said without exaggeration that it was on fire in at least a hundred different places at once, and thus continued burning for six days together . . . [The fire] went on consuming everything the earthquake had spared . . . ; every one had his eyes turned towards the flames, and stood looking on with silent grief, which was only interrupted by the cries and shrieks of women and children calling on the saints and angels for succor, . . . and . . . the tremors, more or less, did not cease for a quarter of an hour together.

So much for that fatal day, November 1, 1755. The calamity it brought is one of the very few that mankind still faces as helplessly now as one hundred and seventy years ago. But here, too, technology will find ways to resist it, even if only indirectly through prediction. For now, however, the sensory organs of some animals seem far superior to our most sensitive instruments. Dogs, especially, are said to become so obviously agitated in the days preceding a quake that monitors in earthquake prone areas use them as helpers. My twenty minutes have now come to an end, and I hope they did not pass too slowly for you.

1931

OSKAR MARIA GRAF AS STORYTELLER

TWO YEARS ago, Oskar Maria Graf published his lovely *Calendar Stories*. One volume is titled “Country Stories,” the other “City Stories,” and it has been rightly noted that this division clearly demonstrates the dichotomy in the development of this “farmer’s son from Lake Starnberg who moved to the city of Munich and became a writer.” Yet Graf did not encounter an entrenched society in either of these spheres of life. And so these “calendar stories” are less repositories of a moral each reader can retrieve than outstretched mendicant hands into which, in passing, one might shamefacedly drop the “meaning” like an alms penny. These stories have no main point and earn their meager wages with frank and exact observations. They are diffident attempts to steer the old calendar stories in a direction which a new school calls “epic.” This concept, first exemplified in the theater, is also useful for prose, and one can say that it accentuates the contrast between the didactic and the introverted, between the storyteller and the novelist. What can be passed on orally, the story’s assets, is namely of another nature than the novel’s stock-in-trade. The novel clearly differs from all other types of prose—folktales, legends, proverbs, comical stories—in that it neither comes from nor feeds into the oral tradition. From a historical point of view, the birthplace of the novel is the solitude of the individual who is no longer able to speak about his most important concerns in an exemplary way, who has no one to counsel him and has no counsel to offer. The ability to pass on what one has heard and to wake within one’s experiences the spirit of the story, the spirit of what can be told, the simple gift of being objective and interesting at the same time, are connected to the complete openness of one’s inner self.

A strong current of air blows through each and every story, even the simplest; we rarely consider how much freedom is involved in telling the most modest story to its best advantage. Every inhibition robs the storyteller of a measure of his power of speech, not merely, as one would expect, of a subject. The epic in its new meaning must, therefore, eliminate the personal from which the novel takes its due. Because genteel self-sufficiency, the sublimation of the personal in reticence on which the novel verges (whereas storytelling avoids it altogether) is for us a privilege of the bildungsroman, it’s natural that it provokes our new epicist. Whereas the bildungsroman

proceeds from the construction of a personality, the writer of epics would rather stick to its dismantling. In the bildungsroman, the hero has his experiences; they shape his personality. Here, in the space of the epic, the experimental subject's experiences diminish him. That is the case with Stationmaster Bolwieser, whom we meet in his peak years in full command of a sexuality that magnificently adorns his wretched married life. Wedekind would have portrayed the demonic side of such unbridled sexuality. For Bolwieser, things happen differently. His sex drive does not hurl him into the abyss, but down a short flight of basement stairs, one step at a time. In the cellar, stored in the coolness like potatoes, lies the moral, which the "calendar stories" did not always reach. "Nature," this moral might go, "is used to making do with the material at hand and proves this, when push comes to shove, even with human material." Bolwieser, the obstinate philistine, the stubborn petty bourgeois, he, too, is unusable. He can only be left to shrink, to sink, to grow more and more stunted, until he becomes a manageable household object in southern Bavaria, where he belongs. He dies off, withering away from the world and from women. Yet the more his human traits shrivel, the more his creature-liness inspires confidence, and in the end, the all but nameless ferryman who was once the stationmaster has become the infallible local weather prophet even though he never asks anything of others, nor do they ask anything of him. "'Cold spell coming,' the farmers say when Xaver Bolwieser, sitting on the bench in front of his cottage, mends his worn fur hat. They need not wait long. 'Steady rain on the way,' they say when he covers his boat in the evening. The next morning, an endless gray rain blankets the area." This is no novel, but a story of someone who withdrew and learned the art of no longer getting in anyone's way. Perhaps it is even a fairy tale: "The Transformation of a Rutting Bull into a Weathermanikin."

1931

ON PROVERBS

TAKE, AS a foundation, the image of women carrying full, heavy vessels on their heads without using their hands.

The rhythm in which they do this is what the proverb demonstrates.

A *noli me tangere* of experience speaks from the proverb.

And through this, the proverb declares its ability to transform experience into tradition.

Proverbs cannot be applied to a specific situation. Rather, they have a kind of magical character: they transform the situation. An individual hardly has the capacity to cleanse all the traces of personal experiences from the lessons learned in life. But proverbs can do this by appropriating those lessons.

Proverbs turn knowledge gained from experience into a wave in the endless, breathing chain of life lessons that come to us from eternity.

Jean Paulhan: *Expérience du proverbe*.

1932

THE HANDKERCHIEF

WHY IS the art of storytelling disappearing? This question had often occurred to me when, of an evening, I sat around a table with other guests and was bored. But on the afternoon when I stood next to the wheelhouse on the promenade deck of the *Bellver* and, with my excellent binoculars, tried to piece together every aspect of the incomparable picture Barcelona offers when viewed from the upper deck of a ship, I believed I had found the answer. The sun sank over the city and appeared to melt it. All life had withdrawn into the light-gray transitions between the trees' foliage, the cement of the buildings, and the crags of the distant mountains. The *Bellver* is a beautiful, spacious motor vessel one would rather see put to more elevated purpose than ferrying people and goods between the Balearic Islands. Indeed, the ship's image seemed to shrink the next day when I saw her waiting at the pier of Ibiza for the return journey, because I had envisaged her course as continuing on to the Canary Islands. So I stood there and thought of Captain O., from whom I had taken my leave a few hours earlier. He was the first and perhaps last storyteller I had ever come across in my life, given, as I mentioned, that the art of storytelling is disappearing. And when I remember the many hours Captain O. spent pacing back and forth on the stern deck, gazing idly now and again into the distance, then I also realized: anyone who has never been bored cannot be a storyteller. Boredom, however, no longer has a place in our lives. The activities that were secretly and intimately connected with boredom are dying out. And hence a second reason the gift of storytelling is disappearing: people no longer weave or spin, make handicrafts or do woodwork while listening to stories. In short: there must be work, order, and subordination for stories to flourish.

Storytelling is not only an art, it is even more an honor, if not, as in the East, an office. It leads to a kind of wisdom, just as, conversely, wisdom often proves to be a story. A storyteller, therefore, always knows how to give counsel. And to receive such counsel, you must be able to tell him a story. And yet we know only how to moan and complain, not how to tell stories. As a third reason I thought of the captain's pipe, the pipe he knocked clean of ashes when he began and again when he had finished speaking, but in between he was happy to let it go out. It had an amber

mouthpiece, and its bowl was made of horn with heavy silver mountings. It had been his grandfather's, and I believe it was the storyteller's talisman. And this is an additional reason why there are no longer proper stories to be heard: because things no longer last as they should. Anyone who has worn a leather belt until it fell to pieces will always find that at some point a story had become attached to it. The captain's pipe must know a great many.

As I was musing on this, on the quay far below me appeared a stocky man with the most massive face I have ever seen below a captain's cap: Captain O., on whose cargo ship I had arrived that morning. Anyone familiar with lonely departures from foreign cities knows or can appreciate what the appearance of a familiar face, even if it is not that of a friend, means in such moments when imminent departure makes any chance of a longer conversation out of the question but at the same time offers the traveler a hat, a hand, or a handkerchief in which his itinerant gaze can nestle before he sails out to sea. And now the captain had appeared, as if summoned by my thoughts. He had left home at fifteen, cruised around the Pacific and Atlantic oceans on a training ship for three years, and ended up on one of North German Lloyd's steamers to America, which he soon left for reasons he did not explain. I could not learn more. A shadow seemed to have fallen over his life, which he did not speak of willingly. As a result, of course, he was missing the most wonderful characteristic of a storyteller: the ability to tell the story of his life, a wick that is consumed by the gentle flame of the recounting. Be that as it may, his life seemed meager compared to that of the ship, whose very ribs and spars he knew how to bring to life. Such was the ship before me when I embarked that morning. I knew as much about the year she was built and her shipping rates, her cargo hold and her tonnage, as I did about the cabin boys' wages and her officers' worries. Yes, those were days when freight transport was still done by sailing ships and the captain himself steered the loads into port! Back then you still heard the quip: "Give up sailing the seas and sign onto a steamship." But these days . . . and then there usually followed several sentences from which one could gather how drastically things had been changed by the economic crisis.

On such occasions, Captain O. would now and then let fall a comment or two on politics. But I never saw him with a newspaper. I will always remember his response when I turned the conversation to that topic one day. "You can't learn a thing from newspapers," he said. "They always want to

explain everything to you.” Indeed: isn’t half the art of journalism keeping your reports free of explanation? And didn’t the ancients set an example for us by presenting events dry, so to speak, drained of all psychological motivation and any opinion whatsoever? In any case, one has to admit that the captain kept his own stories free of any superfluous explanations, and it seemed to me that they lost nothing as a result. Some of his stories were peculiar, but none evidences this particular characteristic as clearly as the following one, which would be reflected in a surprising way that very afternoon on the pier of Barcelona.

“It happened many years ago,” the captain recounted as we sailed off the shore of Cádiz, “on one of my first passages to America, which I had joined as the most junior officer. We’d been sailing for seven days and were meant to dock in Bremerhaven at noon the next day. I made my rounds on the promenade deck at the usual time and exchanged a few words here and there with the passengers. But then I was brought up short; the sixth deck chair in the row was empty. A sense of anxiety came over me, and yet I believe my anxiety had been much greater on those mornings when I silently greeted in passing the young woman who sat in the chair, her hands folded behind her head, gazing fixedly before her. She was very beautiful, yet her reserve was every bit as striking as her beauty. Indeed, her reserve was so great, there was rarely occasion to hear her voice—the most marvelous voice I can remember hearing—demure and smoky, dark and metallic. Once, when I’d picked up her handkerchief—I can still recall my astonishment at seeing the coat of arms: a tripartite escutcheon with three stars in each field—I heard her say “thank you” in a tone that implied I’d saved her life. This time, when I’d finished my rounds, I was about to look round for the ship’s doctor to find out if the lady had taken ill, when I was suddenly enveloped in a whirlwind of white paper. I glanced up and saw the missing woman leaning over the sundeck railing, absently gazing after a swarm of notes and scraps of paper, which the wind and waves were playfully tossing about. At noon the following day—I was posted on deck and supervising the landing maneuver—I again caught a glimpse of the unknown woman. The ship was in the process of docking and the keel slowly neared the pier to which we had already moored the stern. The faces of those awaiting the passengers were clearly visible; the unknown woman surveyed the crowd feverishly. Dropping the hawsers had consumed my attention, and all of a sudden many voices cried out together. I spun around

and saw that the unknown woman had disappeared; it was clear from the movement of the crowd that she had toppled overboard. All rescue attempts were hopeless. Even if we had been able to stop the vessel suddenly, the hull was no more than three meters from the pier and its momentum could not be overcome. Anyone who leapt into the gap was lost. Then the improbable occurred: someone was willing to brave the terrible odds. We saw him, every fiber in his body straining, his eyebrows contracted in intense concentration as if he were taking aim, dive from the railing and as —to the horror of all the witnesses—the steamer's entire length moved to the starboard side and bumped against the pier, the rescuer appeared with the woman in his arms on the ship's port side, which was so empty that no one noticed him at first. He had, in fact, taken aim and landed precisely, dragging her with all his weight into the depths and under the keel, then up to the surface again on the other side of the ship. "When I lifted her up," the man said to me later, "she whispered 'thank you' as if I had picked up her handkerchief."

The voice with which the storyteller had spoken these final words was still echoing in my ears. If I wanted to shake his hand once more, there was no time to lose. I was on the point of rushing down the stairs to reach him when I noticed that the warehouses, sheds, and cranes were retreating. We had set off. Looking through my binoculars, I surveyed Barcelona one last time then lowered the binoculars slowly toward the pier. The captain was standing in the crowd; he must have noticed me at that moment. He lifted his hand in greeting and I waved. When I lifted the binoculars again, he had unfolded a handkerchief and begun to wave it. I clearly discerned a coat of arms in one corner: a tripartite escutcheon with three stars in each field.

1932

STORYTELLING AND HEALING

THE CHILD is sick. His mother puts him to bed and sits with him. Then she begins to tell him stories. How are we to understand this? I began to have some idea when N. told me about the peculiar healing powers of his wife's hands. He said of her hands: "Their movements were most expressive. And yet, you couldn't describe what exactly they were expressing . . . It was as if they were telling a story." We know about the healing powers of storytelling from the Merseburg incantations. They do not simply repeat Odin's charm; more importantly, they recount the circumstances in which Odin first used it. We also know that the story the patient tells the doctor at the beginning of his treatment can be the start of the healing process. This raises the question of whether a story might not create the proper climate and favorable conditions for many a recovery, indeed, whether each and every illness might not be curable if only it were carried along a river of stories all the way to that river's mouth. If one thinks of pain as a dam that impedes the narrative flow, it becomes clear that the dam will burst if the gradient drops sharply enough to sweep everything that stands in its way out to the sea of blessed oblivion. Caresses mark this river's bed.

1932

READING NOVELS

ALL BOOKS should not be read in the same way. Novels, for instance, are there to be devoured. Reading them is a voluptuous act of absorption, not an act of empathy. The reader does not imagine himself in the hero's place, but assimilates what befalls him. The vivid report of these experiences is the appetizing trimmings in which a nourishing dish comes to the table. There is, to be sure, a raw diet of experience—just as there is a raw diet for the stomach—to wit: one's own experiences. But the art of the novel, like the culinary arts, begins beyond the raw ingredients. How many nourishing substances there are that are unappetizing in a raw state! How many experiences are advisable to read about, but not to have! Some readers are struck so forcefully, they would have been devastated had they suffered the experiences directly. In short, if there were a muse of the novel—a tenth muse—her emblem would be the cook. She raises the world from its raw state in order to create something fit to eat, to bring out the fullness of its flavor. One may, if necessary, read the newspaper while eating. But never a novel. These are two conflicting obligations.

THE ART OF STORYTELLING

EVERY morning, news reaches us from around the globe. And yet we lack remarkable stories. Why is this the case? It is because no incidents reach us any longer not already permeated with explanations. In other words: almost nothing occurs to the story's benefit anymore, but instead it all serves information. In fact, at least half of the art of storytelling consists in keeping one's tale free of explanation. The ancients were masters at this, Herodotus foremost among them. In chapter 14 of his third book of *The Histories*, there is the story of Psammenitus. After the Persian king Cambyses had conquered the Egyptian king Psammenitus and taken him captive, Cambyses was determined to humiliate him. He ordered that Psammenitus be made to stand on the side of the road along which the Persian triumphal procession was to pass. He also arranged for his captive's daughter, dressed as a servant, to pass before him carrying a pitcher to fetch water from the well. Whereas all the Egyptians responded to this spectacle with wailing and lamentation, Psammenitus alone stood silent and immobile, his eyes fixed upon the ground. When, soon after, he saw his son being led to execution in a throng, Psammenitus again remained unmoved. But when he then recognized one of his attendants, an aged, destitute man, among the ranks of the prisoners, he began to strike his head and gave every sign of profound grief.—From this story, we can learn the nature of true storytelling. Information is valuable only for the moment in which it is new. It lives only in that moment. It must be completely subject to it and declare itself immediately without losing any time. A story is different: it does not use itself up. It preserves its inherent power, which it can then deploy even after a long period of time has passed. Montaigne evoked the story of the Egyptian king and asked why Psammenitus gave way to grief only at the sight of his attendant and not before. To this Montaigne answered: "he was so replete with sorrow that the slightest additional burden broke the barriers of his endurance." The story can be interpreted this way. Yet there is room for other explanations. Anyone can discover these by putting Montaigne's question to a circle of friends. For example, one of mine said: "The king is not affected by the fate of the nobility, because it is his own." Another said: "We are moved by many things that we see on the stage that don't move us in our lives; this attendant is no more than an actor to the king." Or a third:

“Great suffering builds up and is released only through catharsis. The sight of his attendant was the catharsis.”—“If this story had taken place today,” a fourth said, “all the newspapers would claim that Psammenitus preferred his attendant to his children.” What is certain is that every reporter would come up with an explanation in the blink of an eye. Herodotus doesn’t offer a single word of explanation. His is the driest of accounts. That is why this story from ancient Egypt remains astonishing and thought-provoking after thousands of years. It resembles the seeds that retain their germinative power even after being shut up in the airtight chambers of the pyramids for millennia.

BY THE FIRE

On the Twenty-Fifth Anniversary of a Novel

THERE is a story about Oscar Wilde: one day he found himself in a group of people discussing boredom. Each person had his say. Wilde remained quiet until the end. They turned to him expectantly and he said: “When I’m bored, I pick up a good novel, sit by the fireplace, and watch the fire.”

Indeed, a blazing fire and an open book go well together. And because we are holding one in our hands right now—twenty-five years after it first appeared, Arnold Bennett’s major work, *The Old Wives’ Tale*, has finally been translated—we would like to throw a glance into the fireplace without closing the book. No one is so devoid of imagination that not a single idea occurs to him when he looks into the fireplace. I would like to examine why the spectacle it offers is a metaphor for the novel.

The reader of a novel has a different experience than someone immersed in a poem or watching a play. The novel reader is above all solitary, not only in a different way than a member of an audience is, but also differently than the reader of a poem. The former is part of a crowd and shares in its response. The latter is ready to turn to a companion and give voice to the poem. The reader of a novel is alone and is so for an extended period of time. Moreover, in his solitude, he takes possession of the material more jealously and more exclusively than the other two. He is ready to appropriate it completely, so to speak, quite literally to consume what he reads. He destroys and devours the book’s contents as fire consumes logs in the fireplace. The tension that flows through the work is very much like the draft of air that fans the flames and quickens their dance.

This metaphor presents a different picture than has been usual in discussions of the novel as a genre. In Germany, those discussions began with Friedrich Schlegel. As a result, the fact that Schlegel was willing to recognize only artistic forms of the novel—those of a Cervantes or a Goethe—while refusing to acknowledge the broad tradition of epic narrative, was not without consequences. The novel shares this tradition with the story, which is most evident in the works of English writers: in their novels, Scott, Dickens, Thackeray, Stevenson, and Kipling remain primarily storytellers. Stories flow through them into their books and flow out of their books again as stories. On the other hand, Flaubert, who

embodies the opposite stance, would read his sentences aloud to himself. Their rhythmic perfection, which he tested in this way, simply encloses the reader all the more hermetically within his magnificent works. In them, one sentence is joined to the next like bricks in a wall. Nothing more was needed to establish the cult of "construction" with its echoes of sonorous "prosody," all very much to the advantage of ambitious impotence. But if the novel is a structure, it is less like one designed by an architect than like logs stacked in the fireplace by the maid. It is not meant to be durable but to burn brightly.

Bennett has piled up events of more than five decades in a single space. In that one space, three generations are loosely built one on the other. And these generations rest peacefully on the ashes of those before them. They were merchants who lived in the Five Towns. Over those five decades, the family line is distilled into two sisters, the younger of whom will die without issue, while the second will leave behind one amiable but spoiled heir to both sisters' fortunes. The Five Towns, where they have both their cradles and, later, their graves

> are unique and indispensable. From the north of the county right down to the south they alone stand for civilization, applied science, organized manufacture, and the century—until you come to Wolverhampton. They are unique and indispensable because you cannot drink tea out of a teacup without the aid of the Five Towns; because you cannot eat a meal in decency without the aid of the Five Towns. For this the architecture of the Five Towns is an architecture of ovens and chimneys; for this its atmosphere is as black as its mud; for this it burns and smokes all night, so that Longshaw has been compared to hell . . .

Bennett does not present this hell the way Dickens exposes the hell of early industrial London in *The Old Curiosity Shop*. The two sisters' lives are sealed off from it; while he does not say this explicitly, he conveys it symbolically by having the two sisters grow up in a draper's shop, for which they had been destined from birth. At what cost does the younger one evade this destiny and how closely does the force that tears her away from this house seem related to the force that ultimately undermines it! Toward the end of the novel, the city in which her father founded his shop begins to

change its face. The way of life in which work and leisure were held in balance, the shop was profitable, and life worth living, is dying out. Corporations and trusts have begun casting shadows over the Five Towns. In the beginning of the century, merchants were able to fight off competitors who invaded the field with their placards, gramophones, and rock-bottom prices. The two sisters' lives fall in a historical turning point. The older one still respects conventions, takes over the shop, brings her son into the world, and cares for the house which her younger sister will take over when she returns after thirty years away.

This house has its own character. It is the fold in which the family built its wealth. Gradually, over the course of decades, it evolved from three apartments into a labyrinth in which work spaces, shops, and living quarters melted together into a single structure that offered little in the way of comfort but cemented family customs all the more firmly. On this house, the writer performed one of his literary magic tricks, in which this novel is so rich. It is, despite all the fateful days the two women spend in it, fundamentally nothing other than the domain in which their lives as two young sisters at play and then as two elderly women become strangely and almost indistinguishably intertwined. "The sense of the vast-obscure of those regions which began at the top of the kitchen steps and ended in black corners of larders or abruptly in the common dailiness of Brougham Street, a sense which Constance and Sophia had acquired in infancy, remained with them almost unimpaired as they grew old."

This is dry stuff with which to feed the reader's burning interest. What does it mean? "A man who dies at thirty-five," Moritz Heimann once said, "is, at every point in his life, a man who dies at thirty-five." I don't know if this is true; I believe and hope that it is false. But in the novel, it is absolutely accurate; indeed, one cannot describe the essence of a character in a novel better than this sentence does. It says that the meaning of one's life can be deduced only from one's death. Yet the reader comes across characters in the novel through whom he can construe the "meaning of life." He must be certain in advance, therefore, that he will witness their deaths one way or another—if necessary in a metaphorical sense with the end of the novel, better still with their actual deaths. How do these characters reveal to the reader not only that death awaits them, but a specific death in a particular passage of the novel? That is the question that keeps the reader as irresistibly bound to his book as the flames are to the

logs in his fireplace. In fact, he becomes one with death and soon licks at the characters just as flames dance on a log before the fire consumes it.

It will turn to ashes. This is why the novel, which opens with the sisters' girlhood, is called *The Old Wives' Tale*. In the preface, unfortunately missing from the masterful German translation, Bennett describes how the idea of this novel came to him, long before he began to work on it, at the sight of an elderly woman in his favorite neighborhood restaurant in Paris. Everyone is prone to such thoughts as those inspired in him by the pitiful sight of this woman. But for him, they become the wellspring of a life he preserved completely by transforming it into literature.

"No one dies so poor that he does not leave something behind," says Pascal. Memories may be left behind—but these do not always find an heir. The novelist comes into this inheritance, but rarely without a deep sense of melancholy. What the surviving sister says of the dead one—"Hers had not been a life at all"—sums up the inheritance that falls to this novelist. The dead woman experienced the full fate of her love in a world-historical setting. How meager it appears in the memory the writer creates for it. When alive, the character occasionally had a presentiment of it.

> Sometimes she would think, in an unoccupied moment, "How strange it is that I should be here, doing what I am doing!" But the regular ordinariness of her existence would instantly seize her again. At the end of 1878, the Exhibition Year, her Pension consisted of two floors instead of one . . .

The novel is divided into four books. The last bears the title "What Life Is" and its final two chapters are called "End of Sophia" and "End of Constance." Of all the gifts it offers, this is the most certain: the end. The novel certainly does not need to say it. And yet, the novel is not important because it portrays the fate of a stranger for us, but because the flame that consumes that stranger's fate warms us as our own fates cannot. What draws the reader to the novel again and again is its mysterious ability to warm a shivering life with death.

1933

EXPERIENCE AND POVERTY

OUR CHILDREN'S storybooks contained the fable of the old man who, on his deathbed, convinced his sons that a treasure was buried in the vineyard. They simply had to dig for it. They dug and dug but found no sign of the treasure. But when autumn came, the vines yielded a harvest like none other in the land. The sons realized their father had given them the fruit of his experience: true wealth lies not in gold but in hard work. We were presented these lessons drawn from experience as threats or blandishments the whole time we were growing up: "Still wet behind the ears, and he's got opinions!" Everyone knew exactly what experience was: older generations had always shared theirs with the young. They did so succinctly, with the authority of age, in proverbs or at length and volubly, in stories, sometimes as stories from distant lands recounted to children and grandchildren by the fire. What happened to that custom? Can we still find people able to tell a proper story? How are the words of the dying passed on from generation to generation like an ancestral ring? Who, today, has a helpful proverb ready to hand? Who attempts to deal with the young by evoking past experience?

No, this much is clear: experience's stock has fallen and did so for a generation that underwent, from 1914 to 1918, one of the most horrific experiences in world history. Perhaps this is not as surprising as it seems. Was the observation not made at the time that people returned mute from the battlefield? They did not come back richer in experiences they could impart, but poorer. What flowed into the flood of books about the war that appeared ten years later was anything but experience, which streams from lips to ears. No, this was not surprising at all. For experiences have never been refuted more thoroughly than strategic ones were by trench warfare, economic ones by inflation, physical ones by hunger, ethical ones by the ruling powers. A generation that had gone to school in horse-drawn streetcars found itself under the open sky in a landscape in which only the clouds were unchanged and where, in the midst of it all, in a force field crossed by devastating currents and explosions, stood the tiny, fragile human body.

This monstrous development of technology has brought a completely new kind of poverty to human life. The flip side of this poverty is the oppressive wealth of ideas that has come from the revival of astrology and

yogic wisdom, Christian Science and palmistry, vegetarianism and gnosis, scholasticism and spiritualism and has spread among—or, rather, over—the population. For this is not a true revival, but a galvanization. Think of Ensor's marvelous paintings in which a specter haunts the streets of great cities: an endless throng of petty bourgeois revelers in carnival costumes with flour-covered grimacing masks and sequined crowns streams through the streets. These paintings are perhaps first and foremost a portrayal of the horrific and chaotic renaissance in which so many have placed their hopes. Yet what is clearly evident here is that our poverty of experience is merely a part of the greater poverty that once again has an aspect as distinct and precise as that of the beggar in the Middle Ages. Of what value is our entire cultural heritage if we have no connection to it through experience? The consequences of feigning or misappropriating experience are too clear in the mishmash of styles and ideologies created in the last century for us not to find it honorable to acknowledge our poverty. Let us admit it: our poverty of experience is not only an impoverishment of private experience but of human experience as a whole. It is, therefore, a new kind of barbarism.

Barbarism? Indeed. We say this in order to introduce a new, positive notion of barbarism. For where does poverty of experience lead the barbarian? It leads him to start again from the beginning, to start fresh, to make do with little, to rebuild with next to nothing and without looking left or right. Among the great creators there were always those ruthless spirits who began by wiping the slate clean. What they needed was a drawing board; they were constructors. One such constructor was Descartes, who wanted nothing more for his entire philosophy than a single certainty, "I think, therefore I am," and he took it from there. Einstein, too, was such a constructor, whose interest was suddenly captivated by only one thing in the entire realm of physics, the small discrepancy between Newton's equations and the observations of astronomy. Artists were driven by this same desire to begin again from scratch when, like the Cubists, they adopted the methods of mathematicians and built the world from stereometric forms or, like Klee, adopted the methods of engineers. For Klee's figures were, so to speak, conceived on a drawing board, and like any well-designed automobile, every element of whose bodywork responds to the exigencies of the motor, their expression accords with their internal structure. Their

internal structure rather than their inwardness: this is what makes them barbaric.

Here and there, the best minds began some time ago to reflect on these things. They are marked by their utter lack of illusion about our era and their complete commitment to it. It is the same thing when Bert Brecht declares that communism does not consist in the just distribution of wealth but of poverty, and when the precursor of modern architecture, Adolf Loos, writes: “I write only for those who have a modern sensibility. . . . I do not write for those who are consumed with nostalgia for the Renaissance or the Rococo.” An artist as intricate as the painter Paul Klee and one as programmatic as Loos—both reject the traditional, ceremonious, noble image of man adorned with all the sacrificial offerings of the past and turn toward their naked contemporary who cries like a newborn in the soiled diapers of the present era. No one has greeted this era with as much joy and laughter as Paul Scheerbart. He has written novels that, from a distance, resemble those by Jules Verne, but quite unlike Verne, whose fantastic vehicles only ever transport little English and French pensioners through outer space, Scheerbart is interested in the question of what completely new, lovely, and lovable creatures our telescopes, our airplanes, and rockets will turn the man of yesterday into. These new creatures, by the way, already speak an utterly new language. What is significant about this language is its arbitrary construction in contrast to organic languages. This is the distinctive trait of the language spoken by Scheerbart’s human characters, or rather, by his “folks.” For they reject all resemblance to mankind—a principle of humanism. Even in proper names: the characters in the book named after its hero, Lesabéndio, are called Peka, Labu, or Sofanti. The Russians also like to give their children “dehumanized” names. They name them “October” after the month of the Revolution, or “Pyatiletka” after the five-year plan, or “Aviakhim” after the airline. There is no technical renewal of language; instead it is mobilized in the service of the struggle or of work—used, in any case, to change reality, not describe it.

Scheerbart, to return to him, places the greatest value on housing his characters—and, following their example, his fellow citizens—in accommodations worthy of their status: in adjustable and displaceable houses like those Loos and Le Corbusier have since designed. It is no coincidence that glass is such a hard and smooth material, to which nothing can be fixed. Glass objects have no “aura.” In general, glass is the enemy of

secrecy. It is also the enemy of property. The great writer André Gide once said, “Every object I want to own becomes opaque to me.” Do people like Scheerbart dream of glass buildings because they are apostles of a new poverty? Perhaps a comparison will tell us more at this point than theory. When you enter a bourgeois drawing room of the 1880s, for all the sense of intimacy and comfort it may radiate, the strongest impression you get is that “you have no business being here.” Indeed, you have no business being there because there is not the slightest space on which the owner has not already left his mark: on the shelves with his knickknacks, on the armchair with his throw rug, on the windows with his transparencies, in front of the fireplace with his screen. Brecht had a fine phrase that will help us get away, far away: “Erase all traces!” is the refrain in the first poem of “A Reader for Those Who Live in Cities.” In the bourgeois drawing room, the opposite attitude has become the custom. In return, the *intérieur* requires the occupant to adopt as many habits as possible, habits more suited to the interior in which he lives than to his life. This is clear to everyone who has witnessed the absurd state the occupants of these plush chambers worked themselves into when something in the household broke. Even the way they showed irritation —and they are virtuosos of this affect—bore every resemblance to the reaction of someone who had “the trace of his days on earth” erased. Scheerbart with his glass and the Bauhaus with its steel have accomplished this: they have created rooms in which it is difficult to leave any trace. “In light of the foregoing,” Scheerbart wrote twenty years ago, “we can certainly speak of a ‘glass culture.’ This new glass milieu will utterly transform mankind. And now we can only hope that the new glass culture will not encounter too many opponents.”

Poverty of experience: this does not mean that mankind is longing for new experiences. No, they long to be freed from their experiences; they long for an environment in which they can show their outer poverty and ultimately their inner poverty as well to best advantage, to assert it so purely and clearly that it becomes something respectable. They are not always ignorant or inexperienced. One can often say the opposite: they have gulped it all down, “culture” and “people,” and are now suffering from surfeit and fatigue. No one feels the sting of Scheerbart’s words more than they: “You are all so tired—and the only reason is that you do not focus all your thoughts on a very simple but very magnificent plan.” Sleep follows fatigue, and it is not rare for dreams to compensate for the day’s sorrow and

dejection and show the very simple but very magnificent existence we don't have the strength for when awake. The existence of Mickey Mouse is one such dream. It is an existence filled with wonders that not only surpass but also ridicule the wonders of technology. For what is most remarkable about these wonders is that they are all improvised without the assistance of any machinery out of Mickey Mouse's own body, out of his supporters and his opponents, out of the most ordinary pieces of furniture, or just as often out of a tree, clouds, or the sea. Nature and technology, primitiveness and comfort are perfectly united here. And before the eyes of people worn out by the endless complications of daily life, people for whom the purpose of life seems but the most distant vanishing point in an infinite horizon of means, appears the liberating image of an existence that in every twist and turn is self-sufficient in the simplest and most comfortable of ways, in which an automobile weighs no more than a straw hat and the fruit on the tree swells as quickly as a hot-air balloon. But let us keep our distance, even take a step back.

We are now impoverished. We have given away one piece after another of our human heritage, often pawning it for a hundredth of its value in exchange for the small change of the "up-to-date." The economic crisis looms at the door and behind it, a shadow of the coming war. Holding on is now the reserve of a few powerful people who, God knows, are not more humane than the many; they are in most cases more barbaric, but not in the good way. The rest have to make do as they can and begin again with little. They have made common cause with those who have devoted themselves to the radically new, founded on insight and renunciation. In their buildings, paintings, and stories, humanity is preparing to survive culture, if it comes to that. And the main thing is, they laugh as they do it. Their laughter may sound barbaric now and again. Let it. It may be that the individual will surrender a bit of humanity to the masses who will return it to him one day with compound interest.

1933

THE STORYTELLER

Reflections on the Work of Nikolai Leskov

I

AS FAMILIAR as the name sounds, the storyteller is far from an active, living presence in our lives. He is already a distant phenomenon and is moving still farther away from us. To portray Leskov as a storyteller does not bring him closer, but rather increases his distance.* Viewed from a certain remove, the storyteller is reduced to his most prominent traits. More precisely, they become visible the way the lineaments of a human head or an animal are perceptible in a cliff face to a viewer who stands at the proper distance and angle. An experience we have almost every day dictates our position and viewpoint. It tells us that the art of storytelling is dying out. Encounters with people who know how to tell a story properly are becoming ever rarer. And ever more frequently an awkward silence spreads through a group when someone expresses the wish to hear a story. It's as if a capacity we had considered inalienable, the most reliable of all our capacities, has been taken from us: the ability to share experiences.

One reason for this state of affairs is obvious: experience's stock has fallen in value. And it seems this fall will never end. Every glance at a newspaper confirms that its value has reached a new low, that not only our image of the external world, but also of the moral world, has suffered changes overnight which were once thought impossible. With the world war, it became clear that a process had begun and it has not stopped to this day. Didn't everyone notice at the end of the war that men returned from the battlefield completely mute, not richer in experiences they could share, but poorer? What streamed into the flood of books about the war that appeared ten years later was anything but the kind of experience that flows from one mouth to the next. And this was not surprising. For experiences have never been refuted more thoroughly than strategic ones were by trench warfare, economic ones by inflation, physical ones by mechanized warfare, ethical ones by the ruling powers. A generation that had gone to school in horse-drawn streetcars found itself under open sky in a landscape in which only the clouds were unchanged and below them, in a force field crossed by devastating currents and explosions, stood the tiny, fragile human body.

II

Experience that is passed from one mouth to the next is the source from which all storytellers have drawn. And of all who have written down their stories, the greatest are those whose writing differs the least from the speech of the many anonymous storytellers. The latter, incidentally, can be divided into two groups that do, admittedly, overlap in numerous ways. The figure of the storyteller only fully takes shape for those who can picture both aspects. The saying, “He who travels has a story to tell,” presents the storyteller as someone who comes from afar. But just as enjoyable are the stories of those who have earned an honest living at home and know the local stories and lore. If one wants to represent these two groups through archetypes, then the one is embodied in the sedentary farmer, the other in the merchant seaman. Indeed, each of these milieus has to a certain extent produced its own strain of storytellers. Each of these lines has preserved some characteristics through the centuries. Of the more recent German storytellers, Hebel and Gotthelf descend from the first line, Sealsfield and Gerstäcker from the second. Each of these lines, as has been said, represents only basic types. The full extent and historical breadth of the realm of storytelling is inconceivable without the profound interpenetration of these two archetypes. The Middle Ages, in particular, brought about this interpenetration through its trade structure. The resident master craftsmen and the traveling journeymen worked together in the same workshops, and each master craftsman was a traveling journeyman before settling down in his native land or abroad. If farmers and seamen were the past masters of storytelling, then the craftsman’s workshop was its university. There, tidings of foreign lands brought home by the widely traveled were combined with lore from the past most often preserved by the sedentary.

III

Leskov felt as at home in distant places as in distant eras. A member of the Greek Orthodox Church, he was a man of sincere religious concerns. Yet he was just as sincere in his opposition to ecclesiastical bureaucracy. Because he could manage no better with secular officialdom, he never held any official position for long. Of all his positions, the most profitable for his literary work was probably the one he held as representative in Russia for a

large English firm. In this post he traveled all over Russia, and these journeys increased not only the level of his sophistication but also his knowledge of conditions throughout the land. His travels afforded him the opportunity to become acquainted with the country's sects. These encounters left their traces in his stories. In Russia's legends, Leskov found allies in his battle against Orthodox bureaucracy. He wrote a series of legendary stories centered on a righteous man, rarely an ascetic, most often a simple, active man who becomes a saint in what seems the most natural way in the world. Mystical exaltation is not Leskov's affair. Although he occasionally indulged in the miraculous, he preferred, even in matters of piety, a stalwart temperament. His ideal is the man who can find his way in this world without becoming too involved with it. He adopts a similar attitude toward the material world. It is fitting, then, that he began writing rather late, at twenty-nine years of age, after his travels on business. His first publication was titled *Why Are Books So Expensive in Kiev*? Other short works on the working class, alcoholism, police doctors, and unemployed merchants are the precursors of his stories.

IV

An interest in practical questions is a characteristic trait of born storytellers. Even more markedly than in Leskov, for example, this trait runs through the work of Gotthelf, who gave his farmers agricultural advice, and of Nodier, who wrote about the dangers of gas lighting. Hebel, who slipped pieces of scientific knowledge into the stories of his *Treasure Chest of the Rhenish Family Friend*, is also one of this group. This brings to light an indispensable element of every real story. It serves, overtly or covertly, a useful function. This usefulness may consist in one case of imparting a particular moral, in another of offering a bit of practical advice; a third case may involve a proverb or a maxim—in each case, the narrator is a man of good counsel for his audience. But if the expression "of good counsel" has begun to sound old-fashioned to our ears, that is due to the fact that experience is ever less communicable. That is why we ourselves are no longer of good counsel, neither for ourselves nor for others. Indeed, good counsel is less an answer to a question than a suggestion of how to continue a story (that is already in progress). To obtain it, one would first and

foremost need to be able to tell the story. (Quite apart from the fact that a man is only receptive to counsel insofar as he is able to put his situation into words.) Counsel, interwoven with the fabric of one's lived life, is wisdom. The art of storytelling is coming to an end because the epic side of truth, that is, wisdom, is dying out. This phenomenon is far from new. Nothing would be more foolish than to consider it merely a "symptom of decline" much less a "modern" symptom. It is, rather, a side effect of historical secular forces of productivity that have gradually eliminated the storyteller from the realm of living speech and at the same time have made a new beauty visible in what has disappeared.

V

The earliest evidence of a process that would culminate in the demise of storytelling is the rise of the novel at the dawn of the modern age. What distinguishes the novel from the story (and from the epic narrowly defined) is that the former is inseparable from the book. The spread of the novel was made possible only with the invention of the printing press. What can be passed on orally, the epic's assets, is altogether different from what constitutes the novel's stock-in-trade. The novel differs from all other types of prose—folktales, legends, even novellas—in that it neither comes from nor feeds into the oral tradition. This distinguishes it above all from storytelling. The storyteller finds his material in experience: his own or what he has learned secondhand. And the stories he tells, in turn, become experience for his audience. The novelist has isolated himself. The birthplace of the novel is the individual in his solitude who is no longer able to speak about his most important concerns in an exemplary way, who has no one to counsel him and has no counsel to offer. Writing a novel means taking to an extreme the incommensurable in the depiction of human existence. In the midst of life's fullness and through the depiction of this fullness, the novel makes manifest the profound perplexity of the living. *Don Quixote*, the first great book of the genre, teaches how the greatness of soul, the boldness and helpfulness of one of the noblest of men—Don Quixote himself—is utterly heedless and without the slightest spark of wisdom. If efforts were made now and again over the course of the centuries—most effectively perhaps in *Wilhelm Meister's Apprenticeship*—

to instill instruction into the novel, these attempts always resulted in an alteration of the genre. The bildungsroman, on the other hand, does not deviate in the slightest from the novel's fundamental structure. By integrating social processes into one person's development, it bestows the most tenuous justification imaginable on the orders that govern those processes. The legitimization of those processes is at odds with their reality. It is precisely in the bildungsroman that the insufficient becomes event.

VI

One must think of the rhythms in which epic forms are transformed as comparable to the rhythms of the geological transformations the earth's surface has undergone over millennia. Scarcely any other form of human communication has taken so long to develop or so long to disappear. The novel, whose roots extend back into antiquity, had to wait centuries until it found in the rising middle class the elements necessary for its flowering. Once these elements appeared, storytelling gradually began to retreat into the archaic; although it acquired new material in many ways, this material did not determine it. On the other hand, with the dominance of the middle class—for which the press is one of the most essential instruments in the era of fully fledged capitalism—a form of communication comes into play, which, however ancient its origins, had never before influenced the epic form in a decisive way. Today, however, it does exert decisive influence. And it is clear that it confronts storytelling as something no less foreign but much more threatening than the novel, which it furthermore has led into a state of crisis. This new form of communication is information.

Villemessant, founder of *Le Figaro*, characterized the nature of information in a celebrated phrase. "For my readers," he would say, "an attic fire in the Latin Quarter is more important than a revolution in Madrid." This immediately makes clear that there is much more of an audience for information about one's neighbors than for news from afar. This distant news—whether the distance was geographical in news from other lands or chronological in news from past traditions—once enjoyed an authority that gave it legitimacy even though it was not subject to any controls. Information, however, claims to be immediately verifiable. Its first requirement is that it be "comprehensible in and of itself." It is often no

more accurate than the news that spread in earlier centuries. Yet, while these tidings often adopted shades of the miraculous, it is essential for information to sound plausible. It is therefore irreconcilable with the spirit of storytelling. If the art of storytelling has become rare, the dissemination of information has played a decisive role in creating this situation.

Every morning, news reaches us from around the globe. And yet we lack remarkable stories. This is due to the fact that no incidents any longer reach us not already permeated with explanations. In other words: almost nothing occurs to the story's benefit anymore; instead it all serves information. In fact, at least half of the art of storytelling consists in keeping one's tale free of explanations. Leskov was a master at this (think of stories like "The Deception" or "The White Eagle"). Extraordinary and miraculous events are recounted with great precision, but the psychological context is not forced on the reader. He is left the freedom to interpret the situation as he understands it, and the story thus acquires a breadth that information lacks.

VII

Leskov was schooled by the classics. The first Greek storyteller was Herodotus. In chapter 14 of his third book of *The Histories*, there is a very instructive story. It tells of Psammenitus. After the Persian king Cambyses had conquered the Egyptian king Psammenitus and taken him captive, Cambyses was determined to humiliate him. He gave the order that Psammenitus be made to stand on the side of the road along which the Persian triumphal procession was to pass. He also arranged for his captive's daughter, dressed as a servant, to pass before him carrying a pitcher to fetch water from the well. Whereas all the Egyptians responded to this spectacle with wailing and lamentation, Psammenitus alone stood silent and immobile, his eyes fixed upon the ground. When, soon after, he saw his son being led to his execution in a throng, Psammenitus again remained unmoved. But when he then recognized one of his attendants, an aged, destitute man, among the ranks of the prisoners, he began to strike his head and gave every sign of profound grief.

From this story, we can learn the true nature of storytelling. Information is valuable only for the moment in which it is new. It lives only in that moment. It must be completely subject to it and explain itself immediately

without losing any time. A story is different: it does not use itself up. It preserves its inherent power, which it can then deploy even after a long period of time. Montaigne evoked the story of the Egyptian king and asked why Psammenitus gave way to grief only at the sight of his attendant and not before. Montaigne answered: “he was so replete with sorrow that the slightest additional burden broke the barriers of his endurance.” So Montaigne. Yet one could also say, “The king is not affected by the fate of the nobility, because it is his own.” Alternatively: “We are moved by many things that we see on the stage that don’t move us in our lives; this attendant is merely an actor to the king.” Or: “Great suffering builds up and is released only through catharsis. The sight of his attendant was the catharsis.” Herodotus doesn’t offer a single word of explanation. His is the driest of accounts. That is why this story from ancient Egypt remains astonishing and thought-provoking after thousands of years. It resembles the seeds that retain their germinative power even after being shut up for millennia in the airtight chambers of the pyramids.

VIII

Nothing commends a story to memory more effectively than the chaste brevity that eludes psychological analysis. The more naturally the storyteller avoids all psychological shading, the greater will be the story’s claim to space in the listener’s memory, and the more thoroughly a story is integrated into the listener’s experience, the more likely he will be to recount it and pass it on sooner or later. This process of assimilation, which takes place deep inside us, requires a state of relaxation that is becoming ever rarer. If sleep is the height of physical relaxation, then boredom is that of mental relaxation. Boredom is the dream bird that broods the egg of experience. A rustling in the leaves is enough to scare it away. Its nests—those activities intimately connected to boredom—have already died out in the cities and are declining in the countryside as well. With them, the gift of listening is being lost, and the community of listeners is disappearing. Telling stories, after all, is the art of retelling those we have heard, and that is lost when stories are no longer remembered. They are being lost because no one spins or weaves any longer while listening to them. The more self-forgetful the listener, the deeper what is heard is inscribed in him. When he

is caught up in the rhythm of his work, he listens to the stories in such a way that the art of telling them descends on him of its own accord. In this way, the web is woven in which the gift of storytelling is embedded. Today this web is unraveling on all sides after having been woven thousands of years ago in the domain of the oldest forms of craftsmanship.

IX

Storytelling as it has long flourished in the world of manual labor—rural, maritime, then urban—is itself a form of artisanal labor, so to speak. It does not aim to transmit the pure, intrinsic nature of the thing like information or a report. It plunges the thing into the life of the teller and draws it out again. The storyteller's traces cling to a story the way traces of the potter's hand cling to a clay bowl. Storytellers tend to begin a story with a depiction of the circumstances in which they first heard it, when they don't pass it off simply as their own experience. Leskov begins "The Deception" with an account of a train journey on which a fellow traveler had told him the events he then relates; or he thinks of Dostoevsky's funeral, at which he sets his encounter with the heroine of his story "Apropos the Kreutzer Sonata"; or he recalls an evening meeting with a reading circle in which he heard mention the incidents he then recounts for us in "Interesting Men." Leskov's traces are thus often evident in the stories he tells, if not as traces of the one who experienced the events directly, then as those of the one recounting them.

Leskov himself considered the craftsmanly art of storytelling to be a handicraft. "For me," he explains in one of his letters, "writing is not a high art, but a craft." It is no surprise that he felt an affinity with craftsmanship but found industrial technology alienating. Tolstoy, who must have felt a measure of sympathy for this stance, touches in passing the nerve of Leskov's narrative gift when he calls him the first writer "to point out the deficiencies of economic progress . . . It's strange that Dostoevsky is so widely read . . .whereas I simply don't understand why Leskov is scarcely read. He is a truthful writer." In his cunning and exuberant story "The Steel Flea," which is part legend and part comic tale, Leskov glorifies native handiwork through the metalworkers of Tula. Their masterpiece, the steel

flea, is shown to Peter the Great and convinces him that Russians need not feel ashamed before the English.

The intellectual picture of the artisan world from which the storyteller originates has perhaps never been described in a more significant manner than by Paul Valéry. He speaks of perfect things found in nature—fine pearls, complex and mature wines, highly accomplished people—and evokes "the unhurried accretion of successive and similar causes." The only temporal limit of this incremental accretion of causes is perfection. "In earlier times," Valéry continues, "man emulated this patience. Illuminated manuscripts; exquisitely carved ivories; perfectly polished and precisely cut gemstones; lacquers and hues obtained through a multitude of thin, translucent layers . . . —all these products of a persistent, virtuous industry are rarely made any longer. The era is past when time did not matter. Today no one cultivates what cannot be created quickly." Indeed, we have even managed to abbreviate stories. We have witnessed the development of the "short story," which has withdrawn from the oral tradition and no longer allows for that slow accumulation of thin, translucent layers which offers the most fitting image of the process in which the perfect story is revealed through the stratification of numerous retellings.

X

Valéry concludes this reflection with the sentence "The idea of eternity seems to have faded as the distaste for lengthy tasks has grown." From time immemorial the idea of eternity has had its most powerful source in death. If this idea is fading, we can conclude that the face of death must have changed. It would appear that this change resembles the one that reduced the communicability of experience to the same extent that the art of storytelling has declined.

We can note how, over the past few centuries, the idea of death has lost pervasiveness and immediacy in the collective consciousness. The process accelerated in its last stages. In the course of the nineteenth century, bourgeois society produced a side effect through its hygienic and social, private, and public institutions that may well have unconsciously been its primary goal: it made it possible to avoid the sight of the dying. Death was once a public act in the life of the individual and an exemplary one at that

(consider those medieval paintings in which the deathbed is transformed into a throne toward which crowds throng through wide-open doors). In modern times, dying has been pushed ever more effectively from the perception of the living. In the past, there was not a house, not a single room in which someone had not died. (The Middle Ages experienced spatially what the inscription on a sundial in Ibiza makes meaningful in the order of time: *Ultima multis* [the last hour for many].) Today, people live in rooms untouched by death. They are newcomers to eternity, and when the end approaches, they are stowed away in sanatoriums or hospitals by their heirs. Yet it is the case that with the dying not only do knowledge and wisdom, but especially one's life experiences —that is, the material of which stories are made—become most communicable. Just as when a man's life comes to an end a series of images is set in motion inside him—visions of his own person in which he has encountered himself without realizing it —so does the unforgettable suddenly animate his expressions and glances, conferring on everything concerned with the dying that authority which even the most miserable wretch possesses on his deathbed in the eyes of the living around him. This authority lies at the very source of the story.

XI

Death is the sanction of everything the storyteller can relate. It is death that has lent him his authority. In other words, his stories always refer to natural history. This is expressed in exemplary fashion in one of the most beautiful stories we have from the incomparable Johann Peter Hebel. It is included in his *Treasure Chest* and is entitled "Unexpected Reunion." It begins with the betrothal of a young fellow who works in the Falun mines. On the eve of his wedding, he meets his death deep in a mining shaft. His bride remains faithful to the dead man and lives long enough to recognize her fiancé one day when his body is brought up from the abandoned tunnel, perfectly preserved by the iron vitriol. After this reunion, she dies in turn. When Hebel faced the necessity in his story of making evident the long span of years that had passed, he did so in the following sentences:

> In the meantime, the city of Lisbon in Portugal was destroyed by an earthquake, and the Seven Years' War came to an end, and Emperor Francis I died, and the Jesuit order was dissolved, and Poland was

> partitioned, and Empress Maria Theresa died, and Streunsee was executed, America was liberated, and the combined French and Spanish forces could not capture Gibraltar. The Turks imprisoned General Stein in the Veterani Cave in Hungary, and Emperor Joseph died too. King Gustav of Sweden conquered Russian Finland, and the French Revolution and the long war began, and Emperor Leopold II went to his grave as well. Napoleon conquered Prussia, and the English bombarded Copenhagen, and the farmers sowed and reaped. The millers milled, and the blacksmiths hammered, and the miners dug for metal seams in their workshop under the ground. Yet in the year 1809, when the miners of Falun . . .

Never has a storyteller embedded his narrative more deeply in natural history than Hebel does in this chronology. Read it closely: death does its rounds as regularly as the Grim Reaper in the processions that circle cathedral clocks at noon.

XII

The analysis of any particular epic form must take into account its relationship to historiography. One could go even further and ask if historiography does not represent the point of creative indifference among all epic forms. Written history would then bear the same relation to epic forms as white light does to the colors of the spectrum. Be that as it may, of all the epic forms, the chronicle is the one that appears most unequivocally in the pure, colorless light of written history. And in the broad spectrum of the chronicle, the various ways a story can be told fan out like shadings of one and the same color. The chronicler is the teller of history. Consider again the passage from Hebel: it certainly has the tone of a chronicle, and in it we can easily measure the difference between the historian, the one who writes history, and the chronicler, the one who recounts it. The historian is constrained to explain one way or another the events he is describing; under no circumstances can he content himself with presenting them as samples of what occurs in the world. Yet this is precisely what the chronicler does and none more strikingly than his classical representatives, the chroniclers of the Middle Ages, precursors of the modern historians. By basing their accounts of historical events on the inscrutable design of divine providence,

they threw off from the start the burden of providing a verifiable explanation. Instead they offer explication which does not aim to accurately link together specific events, but to embed them in the inscrutable course of the world.

It makes no difference if the course of the world is determined by salvation history or by natural history. In the storyteller, the chronicler has been preserved in a new, quasi-secularized guise. Leskov is one of those whose work displays this development most clearly. In his writing, both the chronicler with his providential cast and the storyteller with his profane outlook play such important roles that in some stories it is difficult to determine if the web in which they appear is the golden weave of a religious view of history or the colorful fabric of a profane one. Consider Leskov's story "The Alexandrite," which carries the reader back

> to that distant time when the stones in the earth's womb and the planets in the celestial vaults were still concerned with man's fate, not to the present when everything in the heavens and below the ground has grown indifferent to the sons of men and no voice speaks to them or obeys their commands. The newly discovered planets no longer play any role in the horoscopes and there are now a multitude of new stones, all measured and weighed, whose specific weight and density we have recorded, but they no longer herald anything to us nor bring any benefit. The age when they spoke to man is past.

It is clear that one can hardly characterize the course of the world as unambiguously as its illustration in Leskov's story. Is it determined by salvation history or natural history? Only one thing is certain: the course of the world as such is beyond all properly historical categorization. Leskov tells us that the age when man could believe himself in harmony with nature has ended. Schiller called this age the era of naive poetry. The storyteller, however, remains faithful to it and does not turn his gaze from the dial before which the creaturely procession passes, and in this procession Death appears accordingly now as leader, now as the most wretched of stragglers.

XIII

The extent to which the listener's naive relationship to the story is ruled by his wish to remember what he hears has seldom been taken into account. For the unbiased listener, the crucial point is to be certain he will be able to reproduce the story. Memory is the most important epic faculty of all. Only thanks to a capacious memory can the epic assimilate the course of events on the one hand and make its peace with their transience and with the power of death on the other. It is hardly surprising if, in the eyes of that man of the people Leskov once invented, the czar, ruler of the world in which his stories take place, has the most encyclopedic of memories. "Our emperor and his entire family," the man says, "have an astonishing memory."

Mnemosyne, the one who remembers, was for the Greeks the muse of the epic. This name brings the observer back to a crossroads in world history. If, indeed, what is consigned to memory—historiography—represents the creative indifference of the various epic forms (just as great prose represents the creative indifference of the various measures of verse), then its oldest form, the epic, by virtue of a kind of indifference, includes the story and the novel. But when, over the course of centuries, the novel began to emerge from the epic's womb, it became clear that the epic muse—that is, memory—took on a completely different guise than in the story.

Memory forges the chain of tradition which transmits past events from generation to generation. It is the musal element of the epic in the broadest sense. It encompasses all varieties of the epic. Of these, the one embodied by the storyteller is preeminent. It is memory that weaves the net all stories ultimately form together. Each is tied to the next, as the greatest storytellers, especially those from the Orient, were always pleased to demonstrate. In each of them lives a Scheherazade, for whom every episode in a story evokes a new story. This is an epic *memory* and the musal element of the story. And yet this must be set against another, more narrowly defined musal element which first appears in the novel, one which in the epic was still undifferentiated from the musal element of the story. It can, at most, be occasionally divined in the epics, especially in solemn invocations of the muse that open the Homeric epics. What is heralded in these passages is the novelist's immortalizing memory in contrast to the storyteller's diverting reminiscences. The former is dedicated to *one* hero, *one* odyssey, or *one* battle; the latter to *multiple* scattered events. In other words, it is *remembrance*, which, as the musal element of the novel, takes its place next

to memory, the musal element of the story after awareness of their common origin faded with the decline of the epic.

XIV

"No one dies so poor that he does not leave something behind," Pascal wrote. Memories certainly may be left behind—but they don't always find an heir. The novelist comes into this inheritance, rarely without a profound sense of melancholy. What is said of a dead woman in one of Arnold Bennett's novels—that "hers had not been a life at all"—usually sums up the inheritance that falls to the novelist. We owe the most important explication of this aspect of the subject to Georg Lukács, who sees the novel as a "form of transcendental homelessness." At the same time, according to Lukács, the novel is the only literary form that includes real time among its constitutive principles. "Time," he writes in *The Theory of the Novel*,

> can become constitutive only when the bond with the transcendental home has been severed. . . . Only in the novel . . . [is meaning] separated from life, and hence the essential from the temporal; we might almost say that the entire inner action of the novel is nothing but a struggle against the power of time. . . . [And] from this . . . spring experiences of time which are authentically epic because they give rise to action and stem from action: the experiences of hope and memory. . . . Only in the novel . . . does memory occur as a creative force affecting the object and transforming it. . . . The duality of interiority and the outside world can be abolished for the subject if he (the subject) glimpses the organic unity of his whole life through the process by which his living present has grown from the stream of his past life dammed up within his memory. . . . And the insight which grasps this unity . . . becomes an intuitive, premonitory comprehension of the unattained and therefore inexpressible meaning of life.†

The "meaning of life" is, in fact, the center around which the novel moves. But the search for it is nothing more than the initial expression of perplexity experienced by the reader who sees himself transposed into this written life. Here the "meaning of life"—there the "moral of the story":

under these two watchwords the novel and the story confront each other and from them the completely different historical standings of these art forms can be discerned.—If *Don Quixote* is the first perfect specimen of the novel, then the last is perhaps *L'Éducation sentimentale*. In the latter novel's closing words, the meaning the bourgeois age found in all its doings at the onset of its decline has settled like dregs in the cup of life. The boyhood friends Frédéric and Deslauriers recall the friendship of their youth. There was one small incident: furtively and timidly they visited the brothel in their hometown and did nothing more than offer the madam a bouquet they had picked in Frédéric's garden. "They were seen leaving. People were still talking about this scandal three years later. The two recounted it to each other at great length, each filling in details the other had forgotten, and when they reached the end Frédéric said, 'That was probably the best time of our lives!' 'It may well have been! Yes, that was our best time!' Deslauriers replied." The novel ends with that realization, which is, strictly speaking, a conclusion more fitting to a novel than it could be to any story. Indeed, there is no story that could not be legitimately followed by the question "And what happened next?" The novel, however, cannot hope to take the smallest step beyond the limit at which it invites the reader to reflect upon the meaning of life with the inscription "Finis" at the bottom of the page.

XV

Someone listening to a story is in the company of the storyteller; even someone reading it shares in that companionship. Someone reading a novel, however, is solitary, more so than any other reader. (For even someone reading a poem is ready to give voice to the words for a listener.) In this solitude, the reader of a novel takes possession of the material more jealously than anyone else. He is ready to appropriate it completely, quite literally to consume what he reads. Indeed, he destroys and devours the book's contents as fire consumes logs in the fireplace. The tension that flows through the novel is very much like the draft of air that fans the flames and quickens their dance.

This is dry stuff with which to feed the reader's burning interest. What does it mean? "A man who dies at thirty-five," Moritz Heimann once said,

“is, at every point in his life, a man who dies at thirty-five.” There is nothing more dubious than this statement. But it is dubious for one reason only: the tense is wrong. A man—so says the truth that was intended here—will appear *in recollection*, at every point of his life, as a man destined to die at thirty-five. In other words: the statement that makes no sense in relation to real life is irrefutable in the context of remembered life. The essence of the character in the novel can hardly be better depicted than with this sentence. It states that the “meaning” of his life becomes clear only with his death. But the reader of a novel is actually searching for people through whom he can decipher the “meaning of life.” He must therefore, one way or another, be certain from the beginning that he will witness their deaths. This could, if necessary, be a figurative death with the end of the novel. But an actual demise is preferable. How can the characters reveal to the reader that death already awaits them, a very specific death in a specific passage? That is the question that keeps the reader’s burning interest alight over the course of the novel.

The novel is important not because it instructs us by presenting a stranger’s fate, but because the flame that consumes this stranger’s fate warms us as our own fates cannot. What draws the reader to a novel is the hope of warming his shivering life at the flame of a death he reads about.

XVI

“Leskov,” Gorky wrote, “is one of the writers most deeply rooted in the people, and he is completely free of any foreign influences.” A great storyteller will always be rooted in the people, primarily among craftsmen. But just as the artisan class encompassed the worlds of peasants, sailors, and city dwellers in the various stages of their economic and technical development, there is a great divergence of concepts in which their experiences are reflected. (To say nothing of the by no means negligible part merchants have played in perfecting the art of storytelling; they did not contribute as much by increasing the amount of instructive content as by refining the ruses used to capture the listener’s attention. They have left a deep imprint on the cycle *The Thousand and One Nights*.) In short, regardless of the fundamental role storytelling has played in humanity’s household, the concepts which yield the harvest of stories are manifold.

What is most easily grasped in religious terms in Leskov seems to align itself naturally with the pedagogical perspective of the Enlightenment in Hebel, appears in Poe as a hermetic tradition, and finds a last refuge in Kipling in the realm of the sailors and colonial soldiers of the British empire. What all great storytellers have in common is the ease with which they climb up and down the rungs of their experiences as on a ladder. A ladder reaching into the bowels of the earth and disappearing among the clouds is the image of a collective experience for which death itself, the most profound shock in any individual experience, presents neither impulse nor limit.

"And if they haven't died, then they are living still," says the fairy tale. The fairy tale, which remains the child's first advisor because it was once mankind's first adviser, secretly lives on in the story. The first true storyteller was and remains the teller of fairy tales. When good counsel was rare, the fairy tale could offer it, and when need was urgent, the fairy tale's help was closest to hand. The need was the need brought by myth. The fairy tale teaches us about the first measures mankind took to shake off the weight of the nightmare myth had placed on its chest. In the figure of the fool, it shows us how mankind "plays dumb" to protect himself from myths; in the figure of the youngest brother, it shows us how mankind's chances increase as it leaves the prehistoric era of myth behind; in the figure of the man who set out to learn what fear is, it shows us that we can see through our fears; in the figure of the clever wag, it shows us that the questions posed by myths are as simple as the Sphinx's riddle; through the animals that come to children's aid, it shows us that nature is not beholden to myth, but prefers to gather around mankind. Fairy tales have long taught mankind and still teach children today that it's best to confront the powers of the mythical world with cunning and audacity. (The fairy tale divides courage [*Mut*] dialectically between the two poles of cunning [*Untermut*] and audacity [*Übermut*].) The fairy tale's liberating spell does not make use of nature in a mythical way, but signals its complicity with liberated mankind. Adults notice this complicity only occasionally, that is, when they are happy; but children first discover it in fairy tales and it makes them happy.

XVII

Few storytellers have shown as deep an affinity with the spirit of the fairy tale as Leskov. This tendency in him was fostered by the dogma of the Greek Orthodox Church. As is well known, Origen's speculations about the doctrine of *apokatastasis*—the entry of all souls into paradise—which were condemned by the Roman Catholic Church, play an important role in this dogma. Leskov was profoundly influenced by Origen and had planned on translating *De principiis* (On First Principles). In accordance with the Russian folk belief, Leskov understood the Resurrection less as a transfiguration than a disenchantment (in a fairy-tale sense). Such an understanding of Origen underlies "The Enchanted Wanderer." Like many of Leskov's stories, this one is a hybrid of fairy tale and legend, not unlike the one Bloch mentions in a context where he uses our distinction between legend and fairy tale for his own purposes. A "hybrid of fairy tale and legend," he writes, "is what is inauthentically mythical in the latter, a mythical element that appears completely spellbinding and static, yet not outside the human realm. The Taoist figures in legend are mythical in this way, especially the very old ones, such as the couple Philemon and Baucis: magically at large, but naturally at rest. To be sure, there is a similar relationship in the much more limited Tao of Gotthelf: here and there he separates legend from the local character of the spell, he rescues the flame of life, the specifically human flame calmly burning within and without." Those figures that lead the procession of Leskov's creatures—the righteous—are "magically at large." Pavlin, Figura, the toupee artist, the bear keeper, the helpful sentry—all these characters, embodiments of the world's wisdom, kindness, and consolation, crowd around the storyteller. They are unmistakably suffused with the *imago* of his mother. Leskov describes her as "such a profoundly good soul that she was incapable of hurting another person or even an animal. She had such pity for living creatures that she refused to eat meat or fish. My father would reproach her for this . . . But she would answer, '. . . I raised these little creatures myself. They are like my own children. I certainly can't eat my own children!' She refused to eat meat at the neighbors' homes as well. 'I saw them alive,' she would say. 'They're my acquaintances. I certainly can't eat my acquaintances!'"

The righteous man is at once the advocate for all creatures and their highest embodiment. In Leskov, he bears maternal traits that are occasionally raised to a mythical level (which certainly endangers the story's purity). The main character of his story "Kotin and Platonida" is an

emblematic figure in this regard. The peasant [Kotin] Pisonski is bisexual. His mother raised him as a girl for twelve years. His feminine side matures at the same time as his masculine side, and his bisexuality “becomes a symbol of the Man-God.”

This, in Leskov’s view, is a creature’s highest form and surely at the same time a bridge between the natural world and the supernatural. For these maternal masculine figures whose source of strength is the earth and who commandeer Leskov’s storytelling skills again and again are freed from obedience to the sex drive in the full flowering of their virility. For all that, they do not actually embody an ascetic ideal; rather the abstinence of these righteous beings has so little to do with renunciation that it becomes an antithesis to the unbridled lust the storyteller portrays in “Lady Macbeth of Mtsensk.” If the range that stretches between Pavlin and this merchant’s wife spans the breadth of the creaturely world, then the hierarchy of Leskov’s creatures has plumbed its depths.

XVIII

The hierarchy of the creaturely world, the pinnacle of which is the righteous man, descends through many stages into the abyss of the inanimate. In this regard, one particular circumstance must be taken into account. For Leskov, the whole creaturely world expresses itself less through the human voice than through what could be called, after the title of one of his most significant stories, “The Voice of Nature.” This story tells of the minor official Filipp Filippovich who moves heaven and earth in order to host in his home a field marshal passing through his small town. He succeeds. At first surprised by the low-ranking official’s insistent invitation, his guest gradually becomes convinced that the official must be someone he had met before somewhere. But who? He cannot recall. Strangely, the host, for his part, is unwilling to reveal who he is. Instead, he reassures the illustrious personage day after day that the “voice of nature” will not fail to speak clearly to him one day. This state of affairs continues until finally, on the eve of his departure, the guest must grant his host’s public request to let the “voice of nature” resound. At that, the host’s wife left the room and

> returned with a large, polished brass horn and handed it to her husband. He took the horn, put it to his lips, and was instantly

> transformed. As soon as he puffed out his cheeks and blew one thundering note, the field marshal exclaimed: “Enough! I’ve got it, my brother, I recognize you now! You’re that musician from the chasseur regiment, whom I sent, on account of his honesty, to keep an eye on that rogue of a commissary supervisor.”—“That’s it, Your Excellency,” the host replied, “I didn’t want to remind you myself, but to let Nature speak.”

The way Leskov couches the story’s profundity under its silliness offers an idea of his marvelous sense of humor.

This humor is revealed in this story in a still more subtle way. We have heard that the minor official had been delegated “on account of his honesty, to keep an eye on that rogue of a commissary supervisor.” This is what we are told in the recognition scene at the conclusion of the story. But at the beginning of the story we were told the following about the host: “The local residents all knew this man, and they knew he did not hold a high rank because he was neither in the civil service nor in the military, but was merely a minor supervisor in a small local commissary where he had been gnawing away at the government rusks and boot soles along with the rats, and had in time chewed himself together a lovely little wooden house.” In this story, the storyteller’s traditional sympathy for scoundrels and crooks comes into its own. All comic literature bears witness to it. And it is not repudiated on the most elevated summits of art; of all Hebel’s characters, his most loyal companions were Red Dieter, Firebrand Freddy, and his brother Henry. And yet, in Hebel’s eyes the main role in the *theatrum mundi* is that of the righteous man. However, since no one is, in fact, equal to it, the role is passed from one character to the next. Now it is the vagabond, now the haggling Jewish merchant, now the simpleton who steps in to play the role. It is a guest performance in each and every case, a moral improvisation. Hebel is a casuist. He will not declare solidarity with a principle at any price, but he will not reject any either, for any principle may serve as the instrument of a righteous man. Compare this with Leskov’s stance: “I am aware,” he writes in the story “Apropos the Kreutzer Sonata,” “that my thinking is grounded much more in a practical view of life than in any abstract philosophy or elevated morality, but I am nevertheless inclined to think the way I do.” Indeed, the moral catastrophes that occur in Leskov’s world are to the moral contretemps in Hebel’s as the

Volga's vast and silent flow is to the little babbling and leaping millstream. In several of Leskov's historical tales, there are passions as destructively at work as Achilles' wrath or Hagen's hatred. It is astonishing how terribly dark the world can grow for this author and with what majesty evil can raise its earthly scepter. Leskov—in one of the rare traits he shares with Dostoevsky—had obviously experienced moods in which he came close to antinomian ethics. The elemental natures in his "tales of olden days" follow their ruthless passions to the limit. And yet this limit is precisely the point in the eyes of mystics where utter depravity turns to holiness.

XIX

The lower Leskov moves down the creaturely hierarchy, the more obviously his conception of the world approaches the mystical. There is much evidence, as will be shown, that this, too, is a trait inherent in the storyteller's nature. To be sure, very few have dared venture into the depths of the inanimate world, and there are few works of modern narrative literature in which the voice of the anonymous storyteller—who predates all literature—resounds as distinctly as in Leskov's "The Alexandrite." This story is about a semiprecious stone, the chrysoberyl. The mineral is the lowest stratum of creation. Yet, for the storyteller, it is immediately adjacent to the highest. It is granted to him to see in this semiprecious stone, the chrysoberyl, a natural prophecy offered by petrified, inanimate nature concerning the historic world in which he himself lives. This world is the world of Alexander II. The storyteller—or, rather, the man to whom he attributes his own knowledge—is a stonecutter named Wenzel who has refined his art to the highest degree of perfection imaginable. One could compare him to the metalworkers of Tula and say that, for Leskov, the consummate artisan has access to the innermost chamber of the realm of creation. He is an incarnation of the devout. Of this stonecutter, Leskov writes:

> He suddenly grabbed my hand, on which I wore the ring with the alexandrite, a stone that is known to shine with a red gleam in artificial light, and exclaimed: "Look, this is it, the prophetic Russian stone! O devious Siberian! It was always as green as hope and only in the evening did it become suffused with blood. It was like this from the

> beginning of the world, but for a long time it was hidden, buried in the earth, and only allowed itself to be found on the day Czar Alexander was declared of age, when a great sorcerer traveled to Siberia to find it, this stone, a mage . . .” “What nonsense,” I interrupted him. “It was no sorcerer who found this stone but a learned man by the name Nordenskjöld!” “A sorcerer! I tell you, a sorcerer!” Wenzel cried in a loud voice. “Just look at it, what a stone! There is a green dawn in it and a bloody evening. . . . That is his fate, the fate of the noble Czar Alexander!” And with these words, old Wenzel turned to the wall, rested his head on his forearms and began sobbing.

Few lines come closer to expressing the meaning of this important story than those written by Paul Valéry in a completely different context.

“The artist’s observation can achieve an almost mystical profundity,” he writes in reflections on the artist [Camille Corot]:

> The objects illuminated by it lose their names: light and shadows create very particular systems and problems that do not depend on any science or relate to any practice, but are given their existence and value exclusively from certain special accordances between the soul, the eye, and the hand of one born to spot them in his inner self and reproduce them.

Soul, eye, and hand are connected with these words. They define a practice through their interaction. This practice is no longer familiar to us. The role of the hand in production has become more modest and the place it held in storytelling lies empty. (The sensuous dimension of storytelling is not the work of the voice alone. Rather, the hand plays a role in true storytelling, supporting what is said in a hundred ways through gestures seasoned by work.) That old coordination of soul, eye, and hand evoked in Valéry’s words is the artisanal accord we find wherever the art of storytelling is at home. One could, in fact, go further and ask if the storyteller’s relationship to his material, human life is not that of a craftsman, if the storyteller’s role does not consist precisely in reworking the raw material of experience—that of others as well as his own—in a solid, useful, and unique way. Perhaps the proverb, when considered as an ideogram of a story, offers the best idea of this procedure. A proverb, one

could say, is the ruin that stands on the site of ancient stories and in it a moral winds around an attitude like ivy on a wall.

Seen in this light, the storyteller must be counted among our masters and sages. He can give counsel, not as the proverb does, for only a few situations, but as the wise man does, for many. For it is granted him to reach back over an entire lifetime. (A lifetime, it must be said, that includes not only his own experience, but no small array of others' experiences. The storyteller assimilates what he knows from hearsay into all that he is.) His gift is his ability to recount his life. His distinction is his ability to recount his *entire* life. The storyteller is the man who can allow the wick of his life to be entirely consumed by the gentle flame of his story. This is the source of the incomparable aura that surrounds the storyteller, in Leskov as in Hauff, in Poe as in Stevenson. The storyteller is the figure in which the righteous man encounters himself.

1936

*Nikolai Leskov was born in 1831 in the Oryol Governorate and died in 1895 in St. Petersburg. He shared an interest in and sympathy for the peasant class with Tolstoy, and his religious orientation with Dostoevsky. Yet it is precisely those of his writings that express his principles and doctrines most clearly—his early novels—that have proven most ephemeral. Leskov's importance lies in his stories, written in a later phase of his output. Since the end of the First World War, there have been several attempts to introduce these stories into the German-speaking world. Along with the smaller selections of his stories published by Musarion Press and Georg Müller Publishers, the nine-volume edition published by C. H. Beck is most important.

†Translated by Anna Bostock.

Writings by Others

SILENCE AND MIRROR

ERNST BLOCH

I HAVE a rather tetchy friend who sees others very clearly, but himself rather less so. He once criticized a gentleman at his table in such exquisite detail for various and sundry flaws that he quite forgot himself. And so I asked what impression the occupant of his own room would make on him if he were not acquainted with him but instead had to form an opinion based only on the appearance of his shoes and trousers. My irritable friend's lips began to tremble; he must have perceived more in this than I had or could. I later found a report in Herodotus, in content hardly comparable to this story, more elevated and yet nonetheless related to it, of a phenomenon that obviously touches on my friend's and indeed all of our darkened bedchambers, and which, in all its subtlety, other writers have found worth relating in slightly different, more condensed versions. After his defeat in the Battle of Pelusium, Psammenitus, the last Egyptian pharaoh, was being led before the Persian victor, Cambyses. Along the way, the pharaoh first met his daughter, now a slave, and he remained silent. Then the pharaoh passed his son being led to execution; he remained impassive. But when he glimpsed an attendant from his retinue with his hands in chains, Psammenitus wept and loudly bewailed his fate.

Why does the pharaoh weep, I asked my otherwise keenly observant friend, and why does he weep so belatedly? That there was something in this story that concerned us and would repay our attention was clear. Suddenly, the far-fetched incident was present in the house, in the very room we occupied. The simplest explanation was that the servant was the final drop that made Psammenitus' grief overflow. But that was too obvious to be likely; this was a story about a pharaoh, after all, not some peasant. Rather, the pharaoh's grief broke out as late as it did, according to a second explanation, because it had been trapped inside him, trapped by pride. Especially in the proud, the natural interval between the cause of grief, the experience of the emotion, and its expression seems considerably extended. If the cause of grief is like a pot, then even with the usual slings and arrows of misfortune, its lid is not firmly in place but is only put on later. The cause of grief and the sense of suffering coincide only after a delay. Alteration through a misfortune as great as the pharaoh's is like a train wreck, if we

may be permitted this anachronistic image: the wagons have been shoved so far together that only at the sight of the servant does the son emerge and the true melody of the pharaoh's grief resound in a completely different rhythm. And yet this explanation still did not seem quite right because it pushes everything about the pharaoh onto the inhibitions of a great man's pride. This would hardly strike present-day readers as so very extraordinary as it actually does. Furthermore, in this explanation, the servant becomes too incidental, too much of an arbitrary point on which the decisive sorrow strikes its belated, syncopated beat. Isn't it more likely, a third explanation suggests, that our own dark presence plays a role, a particularly muffling and stifling, delaying and obscuring one? To such an extent that what is moving away from us, indeed, what is farthest removed from us, may possibly mirror or betray our own circumstances better than what is closest to us, including our own children? The pharaoh himself, then his daughter, and even more directly, his son and inheritor of his throne, are his own flesh and blood, his immediate experience, and as a result they stand within a zone of silence. The servant, on the other hand, is experienced as something quite distant, strange to him, yet connected nonetheless and so breaks through *and the pharaoh laments*. Just as anyone would weep to see another in his place, in his personal environment, and so connect the intensity of his dark sense of existence with the estrangement of such a sight. The servant in chains, without even a single grand gesture, thus becomes the mirror of one's own state, which is in itself always critical. No one is to be deemed fortunate when facing death and most certainly not when facing the mirror of his death.

THE GIANT'S TOY AS LEGEND

ERNST BLOCH

IF THINGS were different at home, children would not want to read such lurid stuff. But as it is, they need fairy tales and wild men, liberating and shining characters as well. The latter, however, are occasionally of much sterner guise than the fairy-tale heroes in the book of liberation or the rescuers. This is always so where other German pages open to legends telling of lords rather than of the poor or insignificant heroes who have evaded them. Here boys do not run away, but instead earlier fears and former strains, the stables where they labored appear more attractive as soon as they are in the house of the lord who will later eat or spare them, as the case may be. Such wildness is still fitting. It is, first of all, completely different than the power to escape it.

Not only does Hansel take Gretel with him, greater ones also lead her astray. Their faces appear pressed against the windowpanes or gleaming, always staring down from *above*. These are the faces of *legend*; for this, too, grows in the old country. Indeed, fairy tale and legend are so close-knit and proximate, it is almost as if they did not depict completely different times. As if they did not depict completely different worlds: the *fairy tale*, shining into colportage, denotes revolt; the *legend*, descending from myth, denotes endured fate. While the fairy tale contains the uprising of the lower orders and signifies the lifting of a spell before there was one, the *legend* calmly tells of the immutable. Here people endure what befalls them and are obedient, whereupon, in the best cases, they are "rewarded." If the ferryman ferries the dwarves across the river, he receives a magnificent bounty; if not, he wastes away. If the miner throws his ax into the gold-bearing tunnel into which the spirit of the mine has gone, the tunnel will remain open; if he does not follow the rule, the rock wall becomes solid again. In legend, bridegrooms are turned to stone because of their "high spirits," babbling princesses are turned into brooks because they flouted the order to be silent. Even good spirits are equivocal, like water nymphs and especially sprites, or they are capriciously despotic and dealing with them requires an etiquette that, when it rescues someone or breaks a spell, is dictated by the spirits. But those who play along are for the most part frightened peasants or evil counts and countesses whom they frighten to

death. Even when the poor receive help, their escape in legends is not due to their own cunning or intelligence. Instead, ancestral lords grant blessings from above, or rescued knights in the arms of beautiful women offer rewards. An instructive example of the lordly peace and lordly gain which legend fosters in contrast to the always rebellious fairy tale is the Alsatian legend about the giant's toy: the farmer in the giant's apron must simply suffer his fate on the table, without any wiles, and the giants are not as stupid as those in fairy tales, but instead the giant daughter is a princess at play and her father a grave knight who has her carry the farmer back to his field. Because, as he explains, "if the farmer does not work his field, we giants will have nothing to live on in our rocky stronghold." And characteristic of mythical peace, of peace with ancient myths, is the way in which legends were also "Christianized." Here ancient demons, even gods, were not removed from their ground, nor placed under the rule of baptized humans; instead, they remained demonized *ci-devant* lords (who were now doubly to be feared). Or else they were even, apparently, re-created and offered a new setting to the mythical punitive demons, even in Christianity. Thus not only is Princess Ilse turned into a babbling brook in the Harz Mountains (whose nymph she once was), but also the bread defiler Frau Hütt is petrified into a mountain in Tyrol (over which she had once ruled and wielded spells as a goddess). Only the emphasis of the spell is shifted in "Christianized" legends, not the spell itself; so that Gotthelf's half-mythical hailstorm on the wicked servant, Uli, comes from the heights of the petrified Frau Hütt, whereas the gardens of the *fairy tales* are not affected at all. For after all: in the fairy tale, as was clear, Hansel's wiles and the poor soldier's cunning are pitted against mythical powers, even morally tinged ones, whereas legends for the most part only portray diminished mythology and not its opposite. The fairy tale, we noted, is *suspended*, as is the time in which its triumph took place, and its location is lost. The legend, on the other hand, is firmly *grounded* both in time and in place; it is moral like oppression, static like a chronicle, and passive exactly like the ceremony of its contents. In the fairy tale (as in the related Kasperl puppet theater), not even policemen count as human: against them everything is permitted. In the legend, on the other hand, all humans are mythically what they were politically in the era of the Brothers Grimm, in the era of reaction: namely, objects to whom nothing is permitted. The fairy tale is just as much the first enlightenment as, through its proximity to humanity and to fortune, it

constitutes the design of the last; it is always the childlike story of the battle between cunning and light against the mythical powers; it ends as a fairy tale of human fortune, of reflected being as fortune. The legend, in contrast, tells of mythical enchantment, offers heteronomous charms, is a ghost story of an older order, is the only field from which the reaction can gather pictures, mixing them with the fairy tale in false "folklore." The world of fairy tales lives within children and the a priori of revolution. The world of legends survives in its gloomily panic-stricken aspect in dreams and the minds of lunatics and, in its heroically panic-stricken aspect, in reaction. Even the legend's *heroes* are for the most part not human, not Promethean heroes with tensions on high, not tragic heroes; rather, they are nature demons who battle other natural demons for dominance, for sovereignty in the unchanged realm of nature. Thus all folklore that, as is usual today, aligns fairy tale and myth (because the two appear so close, equally close to "nature") strikes in folklore only that which was its enchantment, not its will to freedom. Wagner, with his fascist instincts, certainly saw in fairy tales only "diminished myth" (as his son Siegfried did after him, and Humperdinck composed *Hansel and Gretel* using the Nibelung orchestra). Then again Ludwig Klages, that portentous reactionary, sees in the fairy tale only a "childish offshoot of the visionary life." Yet the legend's "folklore" is nothing more than a reactionary construct and beyond that simply a mirror of terrifying lords and the demonic; whereas the fairy tale's real folklore still blossoms today in children and human happiness. Similarly, colportage does not continue the tradition of chivalric romances but at most brings their adventures, transformed, into the grand fairy tale or the crude fairy tale of liberation: that is why in undiverted "folk romanticism" there are only peasants' wars and no knight's castles, only fairy tales of escape and no superstition. The Enlightenment did not eliminate the afterworld so that the forces of reaction could fill this world with panic.

Here, too, listeners sought something better than the lords intended: heroes who venture deep into the forest and rescue others from spells even if too graciously. There are even *living* transitions from the weak in fairy tales to the powerful in legends, who consequently emerge from the legends. Most of all, the "noble robber" marks this transition. Long before the French Revolution the poor had revered Fra Diavolo, telling stories of him that were half fairy tale, half legend. And in the most beautiful realm of new-old fairy tales and fresh colportage, Wilhelm Hauff paints with kindred

colors both little Muck as an authentic fairy-tale character and the robber Orbasan as the mighty lord of the desert. The strain of longing in little Muck, who picks up every glass shard that gleams in the sun like a diamond, appears related to the splendor of the noble robber Orbasan and his warlike integrity, which Zaleukos always “dreaded.” Such great lords are *representative* of the common people’s desires for revenge or happiness and lead them to victory. This is intensified in some ghost legends: what the peasants wish for but are too cowardly or weak to attain is granted to them by the demons or powerful spirits of the place, as Dolf Sternberger showed with a “Vogelsberg ghost,” although the former are admittedly too irregular and the latter illegal. Another hybrid of fairy tale and legend is what is *inauthentically mythical* in the latter, a mythical element that appears completely spellbinding and static, yet not outside the human realm. The *Taoist* figures in legend are mythical in this way, especially the very old ones, such as the couple Philemon and Baucis: magically at large, but naturally at rest. To be sure, there is a similar relationship in the much more limited Tao of Gotthelf: here and there he separates legend from the local character of the spell; he rescues the flame of life, the specifically human flame calmly burning within and without. As a result, the recognition of the legend as predominantly a worship of power and gilding of spells undergoes no correction; quite the contrary: the mythological demonizing of nature in legend is properly illuminated by these intrusions, whether from colportage or from fairy-tale mysticism. But even in legend there are sometimes human wars and victories over lords that lead to plunder. Even in legend the haunted shot sometimes, against all the rules of the beginning, hits the marks-man who terrifies. Even legend has the Pied Piper of Hamelin, whom children especially understand well; and also the children, according to one interpretation of this wonderful story, are supposed to have been happily led back out of the mountain and off to *distant lands*. Maybe “colportage,” properly applied, will once again be strong enough to loosen myth where it is most dense. The dull uniform opinion that myth is an expanded fairy tale and that the fairy tale is diminished myth merely comes from reactionary Romanticism and ultimately even from Wagner; and the National Socialists completely blur the boundary between fairy tale and myth that the Brothers Grimm had decisively drawn. “For me,” Johann Nestroy says, “the prodigal son was always contemptible; not because he was a swineherd, but because he returned home.”—The explosiveness of

this perception is in the spirit of the Grimms' *Children's and Household Tales* and in the dappled intoxication of the anti-legend or colportage. The proletarian revolution is mostly hostile to "fantastical" literature, but suspense and colorfulness have found a viable refuge in fairy tales and colportage, and from here they can marshal their forces as troops.

THE EMBROIDERY OF MARIE MONNIER

PAUL VALÉRY

SOME PRECIOUS things, like diamonds, happiness, and certain very pure emotions, are the result of an extremely rare conjunction of favorable circumstances. Others are produced by the accumulation of an infinite number of imperceptible events and essential elements over a very long period time and require as much patience as time. Fine pearls, complex and mature wines, highly accomplished people, all bring to mind the unhurried accretion of successive and similar causes. The slow, incremental development of their excellence is aimed at nothing less than perfection.

In earlier times, man emulated this patience. Illuminated manuscripts; exquisitely carved ivories; perfectly polished and precisely carved gemstones; lacquers and hues obtained through a multitude of thin, translucent layers; sonnets ardently awaited, willingly delayed, endlessly reworked by the poet—all these products of a persistent, virtuous industry are rarely made any longer. The era is past when time did not matter. Today no one cultivates what cannot be created quickly. The idea of eternity seems to have faded as the distaste for lengthy tasks has grown. We are no longer willing to create inestimable value through work as steady and unceasing as nature's. Patience and determination weigh on our age, eager as it is to dispatch work quickly with an enormous outlay of *energy* . . .

Yet consider these marvelously colored panels. Their brilliance resembles life's most crimson productions—elytra, bird feathers, shells, and petals. No painting can match the power or delicacy created by these skillfully dyed silk strands. Stitch upon stitch stealthily compose a sumptuous surface. Even the flesh reproduced here is ravishing, and the contour of shoulder or breast is the delicious fruit of a needle's inconceivable artifice.

The embroiderer took her themes from a few poems.

She begrudged neither the time or the labor. These beautiful pages of silk and gold consumed several years of her life. Sacrifice and paradox underlie this work of grace and magnificence in which the insect's stubbornness and the mystic's fixed devotion join in the forgetfulness of self and all that is extraneous to one's desires.

Translated from the French

from THE THEORY OF THE NOVEL

GEORG LUKÁCS

TIME CAN become constitutive only when the bond with the transcendental home has been severed. Just as ecstasy elevates the mystic into a sphere where all duration and all passing of time have ceased and from which he must fall back into the world of time only because of his creaturely, organic limitations, so any close and visible connection with the essence creates a cosmos which is a priori exempt from this necessity. Only in the novel, whose very matter is seeking and failing to find the essence, is time posited together with the form: time is the resistance of the organic—which possesses a mere semblance of life—to the present meaning, the will of life to remain within its own completely enclosed immanence. In the epic the life-immanence of meaning is so strong that it abolishes time: life enters eternity as life, the organic retains nothing of time except the phase of blossoming; fading and dying are forgotten and left entirely behind. In the novel, meaning is separated from life, and hence the essential from the temporal; we might almost say that the entire inner action of the novel is nothing but a struggle against the power of time.

In the Romanticism of disillusionment, time is the corrupting principle: poetry, the essential, must die, and time is ultimately responsible for its passing. That is why in such novels all value is on the side of the defeated protagonist, who, because he is dying, is endowed with the beauty of wounded youth, while coarseness, harshness, the absence of an idea, belong entirely to time. Only as a post-facto correction of this one-sided lyrical opposition to the victorious power does self-irony turn against the dying essence by endowing it, negatively, with the attributes of youth; the ideal is said to be constitutive only for the soul in a state of immaturity. The overall design of the novel is bound to be deformed if positive and negative values are so distinctly divided between the two sides of the struggle. A form cannot really deny a life principle unless it is capable of excluding it a priori from its realm; as soon as it has to admit that principle, it must admit it as positive; and so this principle, not only as an opposing force but in its own right, becomes a precondition of the realization of value.

Time is the fullness of life, although the fullness of time is the self-abolition of life and, with it, of time itself. The positive thing, the

affirmation which the very form of the novel expresses no matter how inconsolably sad its content may be, is not only that distant meaning which dawns with a mild radiance on the far side of the search and the failure to find, but also the fullness of life which is revealed precisely through the manifold failures of the struggle and search. The novel is the form of mature virility: its song of comfort rings out of the dawning recognition that traces of lost meaning are to be found everywhere; that the enemy comes from the same lost home as the knight and defender of the essence; that life had to lose its immanence of meaning so that it might be equally present everywhere.

Thus it is that time becomes the carrier of the sublime epic poetry of the novel: it has become inexorably existent, and no one can any longer swim against the unmistakable direction of its current nor regulate its unforeseeable course with the dams of a priori concepts. Yet a feeling of resignation persists: all this had to come from somewhere, must be going somewhere; even if the direction betrays no meaning, it is a direction none the less. From this feeling of resignation mixed with courage there spring experiences of time which are authentically epic because they give rise to action and stem from action: the experiences of hope and memory; experiences of time which are victories over time: a synoptic vision of time as solidified unity *ante rem* and its synoptic comprehension *post rem*. *In re*, there can be no simple, happy experience of this form or of the times which have produced it. Experiences of this kind can only be subjective and reflexive; nevertheless there is always in them the form-giving sense of *comprehending a meaning*; they are experiences in which we come as near as we can, in a world forsaken by God, to the essence of things.

Such an experience of time is the basis of Flaubert's *L'Éducation sentimentale*, and the absence of such an experience, a one-sidedly negative view of time, is what has ultimately been responsible for the failure of the other major novels of disillusionment. Of all great works of this type, *L'Éducation sentimentale* appears to be the least composed; no attempt is made here to counteract the disintegration of outside reality into heterogeneous, brittle and fragmentary parts by some process of unification or to replace absent connections or valences of meaning by lyrical mood-imagery: the separate fragments of reality lie before us in all their hardness, brokenness and isolation. The central figure is not made significant by means of limiting the number of characters, by the rigorous convergence of

the composition upon the centre, or by any emphasis upon the central character's outstanding personality: the hero's inner life is as fragmentary as the outside world, his interiority possesses no lyrical power of scorn or pathos that might set it against the pettiness of reality. Yet this novel, of all novels of the nineteenth century, is one of the most typical of the problematic of the novel form; in the unmitigated desolation of its matter it is the only novel that attains true epic objectivity and, through it, the positiveness and affirmative energy of an accomplished form.

This victory is rendered possible by time. The unrestricted, uninterrupted flow of time is the unifying principle of the homogeneity that rubs the sharp edges off each heterogeneous fragment and establishes a relationship—albeit an irrational and inexpressible one—between them. Time brings order into the chaos of men's lives and gives it the semblance of a spontaneously flowering, organic entity; characters having no apparent meaning appear, establish relations with one another, break them off, disappear again without any meaning having been revealed. But the characters are not simply dropped into that meaningless becoming and dissolving which preceded man and will outlast him. Beyond events, beyond psychology, time gives them the essential quality of their existence: however accidental the appearance of a character may be in pragmatic and psychological terms, it emerges from an existent, experienced continuity, and the atmosphere of thus being borne upon the unique and unrepeatable stream of life cancels out the accidental nature of their experiences and the isolated nature of the events recounted.

The life totality which carries all men here becomes a living and dynamic thing: the expanse of time which the novel covers, dividing men into generations and integrating their actions in a historico-social context, is not an abstract concept, not a unit conceptually constructed after the event like that of the totality of the *Comédie humaine*, but a thing existing in itself and for itself, a concrete and organic continuum. This totality is a true image of life in the sense that no value-system of ideas enters it except in a regulative function; the only idea immanently contained within it is that of its own existence, that of life as such. But this idea, which reveals more brutally than anything else how infinitely remote we are from the true systems of ideas that have become ideals in the minds of men, at the same time makes the failure of all endeavors seem less desolate. Everything that happens may be meaningless, fragmentary and sad, but it is always irradiated by hope or

memory. And hope here is not an abstract artifact, isolated from life, spoilt and shopworn as the result of its defeat by life: it is a part of life; it tries to conquer life by embracing and adorning it, yet is repulsed by life again and again. And memory transforms the continual struggle into a process which is full of mystery and interest and yet is tied with indestructible threads to the present, the unexplained instant. Duration advances upon that instant and passes on, but the wealth of duration which the instant momentarily dams and holds still in a flash of conscious contemplation is such that it enriches even what is over and done with: it even puts the full value of lived experience on events which, at the time, passed by unnoticed. And so, by a strange and melancholy paradox, the moment of failure is the moment of value; the comprehending and experiencing of life's refusals is the source from which the fullness of life seems to flow. What is depicted is the total absence of any fulfillment of meaning, yet the work attains the rich and rounded fullness of a true totality of life.

Herein lies the essentially epic quality of memory. In the drama (and the epic) the past either does not exist or is completely present. Because these forms know nothing of the passage of time, they allow of no qualitative difference between the experiencing of past and present; time has no power of transformation, it neither intensifies nor diminishes the meaning of anything. This is the formal meaning of the typical scenes of revelation and recognition which Aristotle shows us; something that was pragmatically unknown to the heroes of the drama enters their field of vision and, in the world thus altered, they have to act otherwise than they might wish to act. But the force of the newly introduced factor is not diminished by a time perspective, it is absolutely homogeneous with and equivalent to the present. Similarly, the passage of time alters nothing in the epic. In adapting *The Song of the Nibelungs*, Hebbel was able to take over without change Kriemhild's and Hagen's inability to forget—the precondition of their revenge—because such an inability belongs essentially to drama. In *The Divine Comedy*, the remembered earthly life of each character is as present to their souls as is Dante, to whom they are speaking, or as is the actual place of their punishment or reward. As for lyric poetry, change alone is essential for any lyrical experience of the past; lyric poetry knows no object, structured as such, that might exist either in the vacuum of timelessness or in the atmosphere of passing time: it gives form to the

process of remembering or forgetting, and the object is only a pretext for lived experience.

Only in the novel and in certain epic forms resembling the novel does memory occur as a creative force affecting the object and transforming it. The genuinely epic quality of such memory is the affirmative experience of the life process. The duality of interiority and the outside world can be abolished for the subject if he (the subject) glimpses the organic unity of his whole life through the process by which his living present has grown from the stream of his past life dammed up within his memory. The surmounting of duality—that is to say the successful mastering and integration of the object—makes this experience into an element of authentically epic form.

The mood-conditioned pseudo-lyricism of the novel of disillusionment betrays itself most obviously by the fact that subject and object are sharply separated in the experience of remembering; memory, from the viewpoint of present subjectivity, grasps the discrepancy between the object as it was in reality and the subject's ideal image of it. The harsh and depressing quality of such works is therefore due not so much to the intrinsically sad nature of the content as to the unresolved dissonance of the form—to the fact that the object of experience is constructed in accordance with the formal laws of drama, whereas the experiencing subject is a lyrical one.

Drama, lyric poetry and the epic, whatever the hierarchy in which we may place them, are not the thesis, antithesis and synthesis of a dialectical process; each of them is a means, qualitatively quite heterogenous from the others, of giving form to the world. Each form appears positive because it fulfills its own structural laws: the affirmation of life that seems to emanate from it as a mood is nothing other than the resolving of its form-conditioned dissonances, the affirmation of its own, form-created substance.

The objective structure of the world of the novel shows a heterogeneous totality, regulated only by regulative ideas, whose meaning is prescribed but not given. That is why the unity of the personality and the world—a unity which is dimly sensed through memory, yet which once was part of our lived experience—that is why this unity in its subjectively constitutive, objectively reflexive essence is the most profound and authentic means of accomplishing the totality required by the novel form. The subject's return home to itself is to be found in this experience, just as the anticipation of this return and the desire for it lie at the root of the experience of hope. It is this return home that, in retrospect, completes everything that was begun,

interrupted and allowed to fall by the way—completes it and turns it into rounded action. The lyrical character of moods is transcended in the mood of experiencing this homecoming because it is related to the outside world, to the totality of life. And the insight which grasps this unity, because it is thus related to the object, rises above mere analysis; it becomes an intuitive, premonitory comprehension of the unattained and therefore inexpressible meaning of life—the innermost core of all action made manifest.

1916
Translated by Anna Bostock

ON SADNESS

MICHEL DE MONTAIGNE

I AM OF those least susceptible to this emotion, and neither care for it nor think much of it, even though the world seems to have decided by common consent to hold it in particular esteem. They clothe wisdom, virtue, and conscience with it: a foolish and monstrous ornament. The Italians have more suitably baptized wickedness with the name *tristezza*, for it is a quality that is always harmful, always mad, and the Stoics forbid this sentiment to their sages since it is always base and cowardly, But there is a tale that says Psammenitus, the King of Egypt, having been defeated and taken prisoner by Cambyses, the King of Persia, remained silent and impassive at the sight of his captive daughter passing before him dressed as a servant sent to draw water from a well. He kept his eyes fixed on the ground while his friends about him wept and lamented. And when, soon after, he saw his son led away to execution, he kept the same countenance. Yet when he noticed one of his household staff among the captives, he began to strike his head and express extreme grief.

This could be compared to what we recently saw occur with one of our princes, who was at Trent when he learned of the death of his elder brother, a brother on whom the support and hope of the entire family had rested. Soon after, he was told of the death of his younger brother, the family's second hope. He withstood these two blows with exemplary fortitude, but when one of his servants died a few days later, he let himself be carried away by this last misfortune and, dropping his resolution, he abandoned himself to such wild sorrow and grief, some concluded that only this final assault had touched him to the quick. But in truth he was so replete with sorrow that the slightest additional burden broke the barriers of his endurance. We could, I think, interpret our first story the same way, did it not go on to relate that when Cambyses asked Psammenitus the reason why, after having remained unmoved by his son's and daughter's misfortune, he reacted to that of his servant with so little forbearance. "It is because only this last misfortune can be expressed with tears," he replied; "the first two exceed all means of expression."

Perhaps a similar conceit was guiding the imagination of the painter in antiquity who had to portray the grief of those attending the sacrifice of

Iphigenia according to the degree of each one's interest in this beautiful and innocent young woman's death and, having exhausted all the resources of his art, when it came to painting her father, the artist painted him with his face covered, as if no countenance could express such intensity of sorrow. That is why poets imagine the wretched Niobe, overwhelmed with grief at having first lost seven sons and as many daughters immediately after, as finally turned to stone,

Diriguisse malis

(Petrified by such affliction*)

in order to express the bleak, deaf, and mute stupor that overcomes us when our misfortunes are too great to bear.

In truth, the force of an affliction, at its most extreme, stuns the soul to its very core and deprives it of its freedom of action, much as in the alarm of hearing very bad news, we are dazed, stupefied, almost paralyzed in all our limbs, such that when the soul later gives way to tears and lamentation, it seems to disengage itself, to find release, and gain a wider scope of movement and ease,

Et via vix tandem voci laxata dolore est.

(At last grief opened a passage for his voice.†)

In the war King Ferdinand waged around Buda against the widow of King John of Hungary, Raïsciac, a German officer, seeing his men bring in the body of a cavalier whose exceeding gallantry in battle had been witnessed by all, joined in the general mourning. As curious as the others to know who the man was, Raïsciac found, when the man's armor was removed, that it was his own son. Amid the general weeping, he alone stood upright, not uttering a word or shedding a tear, his eyes fixed on the corpse until the intensity of his sorrow froze his vital powers and he fell to the ground, stone dead.

Chi puo dir com' egli arde é in picciol fuoco, (He who can express how ardently he burns is scarcely afire,‡)

say lovers who want to describe an unbearable passion:

misero quod omnes
Eripit sensus mihi. Nam simul te,
Lesbia, aspexi, nihil est super mi
Quod loquar amens

Lingua sed torpet, tenuis sub artus
Flamma dimana, sonitu suopte
Tinniunt aures, gemina tegentur
Lumina nocte.

(I am miserable, indeed, deprived of all my senses. As soon as I catch sight of you, Lesbia, I lose my reason and cannot utter a word; my tongue freezes; a slender flame spreads through my limbs, my ears ring and darkness covers my eyes.[§])

Also, in the quickest and most ardent heat of transport, we are in no fit state to deploy our complaints or persuasions: the soul is then burdened with heavy thoughts and the body brought low, languishing for love. This is sometimes the source of those unexpected fits of impotence that surprise the lover so unseasonably and the chill that overcomes him by dint of extreme ardor in the throes of delight. All passions that can be relished and digested are necessarily mediocre ones.

Curae leves loquuntur, ingentes stupent,
(Light troubles speak, great ones are mute,[‖])

The surprise of an unexpected joy leaves us just as stunned:
Ut me conspexit venientem, et Troia circum
Arma amens vidit, magnis exterrita monstris, Diriguit visu in medio,
calor ossa reliquit, Labitur, et long vix tempore fatur.

(As soon as she saw me coming surrounded by Trojan arms, she froze, terrified at such omens. All heat left her limbs, she fell to the ground in a faint and for a long time could not speak a word.[¶])

In addition to the Roman woman who dropped dead in joyful surprise on seeing her son return safe from the rout at Cannae, Sophocles and Dionysius the Tyrant both died of happiness, as did Talva in Corsica on reading news of the honors the Roman Senate had bestowed upon him. In our century, we have the example of Pope Leo X, who experienced such excessive transports of joy on being told of the capture of Milan, a thing he had ardently desired, that he succumbed to a fever and died. And in even more notable testimony of human frailty, the ancients recorded that

Diodorus the Dialectician dropped dead, overcome by an extreme sense of shame when he was unable to refute an argument put to him before the public in his school.

I am rarely subject to such violent emotions. I am not of a sensitive nature and I thicken and toughen my skin daily through reasoning.

Translated from the French

*Ovid, *Metamorphoses*, VI, 304.

†Virgil, *Aeneid*, XI, 151.

‡Petrarch, Sonnet 137.

§Catullus, LI.

‖Seneca, *Hippolitus*, II, iii, 607.

¶ Virgil, *Aeneid*, III, 306–310.

from THE HISTORIES

Book III, Chapter 14

HERODOTUS

TEN DAYS passed, and Cambyses, wishing to see what stuff the Egyptian king Psammenitus was made of—he had been but six months on the throne—forced him, with other Egyptians, to witness from a seat in the city outskirts a spectacle deliberately devised to humiliate him. First, he had his daughter dressed like a slave and sent out with a pitcher to fetch water, accompanied by other young girls similarly dressed and chosen from noble families. The girls cried bitterly as they passed the place where their fathers sat watching them, and the fathers, in their turn—all but Psammenitus himself—wept and lamented no less bitterly at the sight of such an insult to their children. Psammenitus, however, after a single glance of recognition, bent to the ground in silence. The girls with their pitchers passed on, and then came the king's son with two thousand others of the same age, their mouths bridled and a rope round their necks, on their way to execution for the murder of the Mytileneans at Memphis and the destruction of the ship—for the sentence of the royal judges had been that for each man ten Egyptian noblemen should die. Psammenitus watched them pass, and knew that his son was going to his death; but, though the other Egyptians who were sitting near him continued to weep and to show every sign of distress, he did just what he had done before at the sight of his daughter. So the young men, too, passed on; and then there chanced to walk by the place where Psammenitus, son of Amasis, sat with the others in the city outskirts, an old man who had once been the king's friend and had dined at his table, but had been stripped of his fortune and was now nothing more than a beggar trying to get what he could from the soldiers. At the sight of him Psammenitus burst into tears, and called him by name, and beat his head in distress. Guards were standing near, whose duty it was to report to Cambyses exactly how Psammenitus behaved as each of the processions went by, and Cambyses was so much amazed at what he heard, that he sent a messenger to Psammenitus to ask how he could behave as he did. "Your master Cambyses," the messenger said, "asks why it is, that you made no sound and shed no tear when you saw your daughter insulted and your son going to his death, yet honoured with those signs of grief a beggar who, he

understands, is not even related to you." "Son of Cyrus," was the answer, "my own suffering was too great for tears, but I could not but weep for the trouble of a friend, who has fallen from great wealth and good fortune and been reduced to beggary on the threshold of his old age."

When this answer was reported, it was recognized as just, and the Egyptians relate that Croesus—who, as it happened, had accompanied Cambyses in the expedition against Egypt—wept when he heard it, as did the Persians who were present, and that even Cambyses felt a touch of pity—for he at once gave orders that Psammenitus' son should be reprieved from the sentence of death, and that Psammenitus himself should be brought before him from the place where he sat in the city outskirts.

Translated from the Greek by Aubrey de Sélincourt, revised by John Marincola

from THE TREASURE CHEST OF THE RHENISH FAMILY FRIEND

JOHANN PETER HEBEL

UNEXPECTED REUNION

A GOOD fifty years ago and more in Falun in Sweden, a young miner kissed his pretty young fiancée and said to her, “On Saint Lucia’s Day the pastor will bless our love. We will become man and wife and build ourselves a little nest of our own.” “May it be filled with peace and love,” the lovely bride-to-be said with a gentle smile, “for you are the world to me, and without you I would rather be in the grave than anywhere else.” Before Saint Lucia’s Day, however, when the pastor had called out their names in church for the second time, “If any of you know just cause or impediment why these persons should not be joined together in holy matrimony,” Death came forward. For when the young man passed her house the next day in his black miner’s suit—a miner is always dressed in funeral clothes—he tapped twice on her window and wished her good morning, but not good evening. He never returned from the mine and in vain did she sew that same morning a red border on a black neckerchief for him to wear on their wedding day. When he did not come back, she put it away and wept for him and never forgot him.

In the meantime, the city of Lisbon in Portugal was destroyed by an earthquake, and the Seven Years’ War came to an end, and Emperor Francis I died, and the Jesuit order was dissolved, and Poland was partitioned, and Empress Maria Theresa died, and Streunsee was executed, America was liberated, and the combined French and Spanish forces could not capture Gibraltar. The Turks imprisoned General Stein in the Veterani Cave in Hungary, and Emperor Joseph died too. King Gustav of Sweden conquered Russian Finland, and the French Revolution and the long war began, and Emperor Leopold II went to his grave as well. Napoleon conquered Prussia, and the English bombarded Copenhagen, and the farmers sowed and reaped. The millers milled, and the blacksmiths hammered, and the miners dug for metal seams in their workshop under the ground.

Yet in the year 1809, just before or after Saint John’s Eve, when the miners of Falun were digging to open a passage between two shafts some

four hundred feet below ground, they dug out of the rubble and vitriol water a young man's body, saturated with iron vitriol but otherwise perfectly preserved and unchanged so that his features and his age were completely identifiable, as if he had died only an hour before or simply nodded off at work. But when they brought him above ground, his father and mother, his friends and acquaintances were long dead. No one recognized the sleeping youth or remembered his misfortune until the woman arrived who was once engaged to the miner who had gone into the shaft one day and never returned. Gray and wizened, she hobbled up on her crutch and recognized her fiancé. More in joy and delight than grief, she sank onto the beloved corpse and it took her some time to recover from the violently stirred emotions. "He is my betrothed," she finally said, "whom I have mourned for fifty years and whom God has allowed me to see once more before I die. Eight days before our wedding, he went into the mine and never came back." All those around her were moved to sorrow and tears when they saw the former bride now a figure of withered old age and the groom still in the flower of youth and saw how the flame of young love was rekindled in her breast after fifty years; nevertheless, his lips did not stretch into a smile nor did his eyes open in recognition; and they saw how she, his only relation, finally had the miners carry his body into her home until a grave was prepared for him in the churchyard. The following day, when the grave was ready in the churchyard and the miners came to get him, she opened a small chest and draped the black silk neckerchief with the red border over him and then accompanied him in her Sunday dress as if it were her wedding day and not the day of his burial. As they lowered him into his grave in the churchyard, she said, "Sleep well for another day or ten in your cold wedding bed and don't let the time weigh heavily on you. I have a few things left to do and will join you soon, and soon day will dawn again. What the earth returned to me once, it will not hold back a second time," she said as she walked away and looked back once more.

KANNITVERSTAN

Every day we certainly have the opportunity, in Emmendingen or Gundelfingen or even in Amsterdam, to contemplate, if we are so inclined, the impermanence of earthly things and find contentment in our lot, even if

there aren’t many roast squabs flying about ready to drop in our laps. Yet through the most curious roundabout way and by mistake, a German apprentice artisan in Amsterdam stumbled on and recognized the truth. For when he arrived in this large, wealthy commercial city full of magnificent houses, swaying ships, and busy people, his eye was immediately caught by an enormous and attractive house, the likes of which he had not seen on his entire journey from Tuttlingen to Amsterdam. For a long time he gazed in wonder at the splendid building with its six chimneys, its elegant cornices, and its high windows, all of them taller than the door to his father’s house. Finally he could not refrain from addressing a passerby. “My good friend,” our apprentice said, “could you tell me the name of the gentleman who owns this marvelous house with its window boxes full of tulips, blue star blossoms, and stocks?” But the man, who no doubt had more important things to attend to and who unfortunately understood exactly as much of the German language as our questioner Dutch, which is to say not a word, merely responded brusquely, “Kannitverstan,” before bustling off. This was a Dutch word—or three, if looked at properly—that means something to the effect of *I can’t understand you.* But our good stranger believed it to be the name of the gentleman he had asked about. “He must be an awfully wealthy man, this Mr. Kannitverstan,” he thought and continued on his way. Up one street and down the next, he finally came to the bay in that city which they call Het Ey, or The Y. Here our apprentice found rows and rows of ships and masts, and at first he had no idea how he could possibly see enough of all these remarkable sights with just two eyes, but then his attention was caught by a vast ship that had just returned from the East Indies and was being unloaded. Long rows of crates and bales were already piled on top of and next to one another on the quay and a steady stream of barrels filled with sugar and coffee, rice and pepper, with even a few—begging your pardon—mouse droppings mixed in. He watched for a long time, then finally asked a stevedore carrying a crate on his shoulder what the name of the fortunate man was for whom the sea had brought so many goods to shore. “Kannitverstan,” was the answer. At this he thought, “Aha, is that how it is? No wonder a man for whom the sea washes such treasures ashore can afford to build such houses in this world and fill his gilded flowerpots with tulips.” He then retraced his steps and began to ponder sadly how poor a man he was, surrounded by so many rich people in the world. But just as he was thinking, “If only I had it as good as this Mr. Kannitverstan, just

once . . .” he turned a corner and came upon a long funeral procession. Four horses, draped in black, were slowly and mournfully drawing a hearse, also draped in black, as if they knew they were taking a dead man to his final rest. A long train of the deceased’s friends and acquaintances followed, two by two, wrapped up in black coats and silent. A lonely bell tolled in the distance. Our stranger was overcome with that sense of melancholy no one can escape at the sight of a coffin, and he stood respectfully, hat in hand, until everyone had passed by. But he approached the last man in the procession, who at that moment was calculating in silence how much profit he would make on his cotton if the price of a hundredweight were increased by ten guilders, and gently took hold of the man’s cloak, then naively begged his pardon. “The man for whom the bell tolls whose procession you’re following so full of sorrow and deep in thought,” he said, “must have been a good friend of yours.” “Kannitverstan,” was the reply. At this, our good man from Tuttlingen shed a few large tears, his heart grew heavy and then light again. “Poor Kannitverstan,” he exclaimed, “what good are all your riches to you now? No more than my poverty will one day be to me: good for a shroud and a winding sheet; and of all your beautiful flowers, perhaps a sprig of rosemary on your cold chest or a branch of rue.” Mulling over these thoughts, he followed the dead man all the way to the graveside, as if he were part of the funeral procession, and watched as the supposed Mr. Kannitverstan was lowered to his final resting place. He was more deeply moved by the Dutch funeral oration, of which he understand not a single word, than by many he’d heard in Germany without paying the slightest attention. Finally, with a light heart, he went off with the others, ate a piece of Limburger cheese with a hearty appetite in an inn where they understood German, and whenever he began to feel dejected at the thought that so many people in the world were so rich and he so poor, he simply remembered Mr. Kannitverstan of Amsterdam with his grand house, his rich ship, and his narrow grave.

HOW FIREBRAND FREDDY ESCAPED FROM PRISON ONE DAY AND SAFELY CROSSED THE BORDER

One day, after Firebrand Freddy had found his way out of prison entirely on his own and thought, “Best not wake the jailer at this late hour,” and while

warrants for his arrest were already winging their way along all the roads ahead of him, his luck still hadn't run out when he reached a small town on the border. After the sentry stopped him and asked who he was, what he was called, and what he was up to, Freddy asked him earnestly, "Do you speak Polish?" The sentry said, "Sure, I speak foreign a bit. But I'm not aware as how any of it is Polish."—"Well, if that's how it is," Freddy said, "we'll have some trouble understanding each other. Is there an officer or constable at the gate?" The sentry went to find the gatekeeper and told him there was a Pole at the barrier with whom he was having trouble communicating. The gatekeeper came and began by apologizing for not speaking much Polish either. "Not many people pass through here," he said, "and they'll be hard put to find anyone in the entire town able to interpret."—"If only I'd known," Freddy said and looked at the watch he had found hanging on some hook along the way, "I'd have kept going an hour or two to the next town. The moon will rise at nine." The gatekeeper said, "In that case it would be best if you passed right on through without stopping. Our little town's not very large," and was happy to be rid of him.

And so Freddy walked cheerfully through the gate. He didn't stay any longer in the small town than was necessary to teach a thing or two to a goose that was out on the street later than it should have been. "You geese just won't do as you're told," he said. "When evening comes, you should be at home or under someone's care." And so Freddy grabbed it firmly by the neck and bundled it just like that under his coat, which he'd also borrowed from a stranger along the way. But when he reached the opposite gate, once again he didn't trust the guards to keep the peace. He was three steps from the sentry box when the sentry inside began to stir. In a hearty voice, Freddy called out, "Who goes there—friend or foe!" The soldier answered good-naturedly, "Friend!" And so Freddy walked happily out of the town and over the border.

SELECTED SOURCES

BY WALTER BENJAMIN

“Johann Peter Hebel”: Radio talk on the Südwestdeutscher Rundfunk, October 29, 1929.

“The Crisis of the Novel”: “Krisis des Romans,” *Die Gesellschaft* no. 7, 1 (1930).

“Mulberry Omelet”: “Maulbeer-Omelette,” *Frankfurter Zeitung*, May 29, 1930 (last of five short texts under the general title “Essen”), and *Neue Leipziger Zeitung*, June 8, 1930.

“The Lisbon Earthquake”: “Das Erdbeben von Lissabon,” radio talk on the Berliner Rundfunk, October 31, 1931.

“Oskar Maria Graf as Storyteller”: “Oskar Maria Graf als Erzähler,” *Frankfurter Zeitung*, November 22, 1931.

“On Proverbs”: “Über Sprichwörter,” fragment written c. 1932, published posthumously in *Gesammelte Schriften* VI (Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 1985).

“The Handkerchief”: “Das Taschentuch,” *Frankfurter Zeitung*, November 24, 1932.

“Storytelling and Healing”: “Erzählung und Heilung,” Frankfurter *Zeitung*, November 15, 1933. Published under the pseudonym Detlef Holz.

“Reading Novels”: “Romane lesen,” written c. 1933, published posthumously in *Gesammelte Schriften* IV.2 (Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 1972).

“The Art of Storytelling”: “Kunst zu erzählen,” written c. 1933, published posthumously in *Gesammelte Schriften* IV.2 (Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 1972).

“By the Fire”: “Am Kamin,” *Frankfurter Zeitung*, May 23, 1933.

“Experience and Poverty”: “Erfahrung und Armut,” *Die Welt im Wort* no. 1, 10 (1933).

“The Storyteller: Reflections on the Work of Nikolai Leskov”: “Der Erzähler: Betrachtungen zum Werk Nikolai Lesskows,” *Orient und Occident: Blätter für Theologie, Ethik und Soziologie* 3 (1936 [1937]).

BY ERNST BLOCH

“Silence and Mirror”: “Schweigen und Spiegel,” in *Spuren* (Berlin: Paul Cassirer, 1930).

“The Giant’s Toy as Legend”: “Das Riesenspielzeug als Sage,” in *Erbschaft dieser Zeit* (Zürich: Oprecht & Helbling, 1935).

BY PAUL VALÉRY

“The Embroidery of Marie Monnier”: “Les Broderies de Marie Monnier,” in *Broderies de Marie Monnier* (Paris: Galérie E. Druet, 1924); included in Valéry’s *Petit recueil de paroles de circonstance* (1926) and *Pièces sur l’art* (Paris: Maurice Darantière, 1931 [1st edition]; Gallimard, 1934 [2nd edition]).

BY GEORG LUKÁCS

“From *The Theory of the Novel*”: “Die Theorie des Romans,” *Zeitschrift für Ästhetik und allgemeine Kunstwissenschaft* 11 (1916).

BY JOHANN PETER HEBEL

“From *The Treasure Chest of the Rhenish Family Friend*”: “Unexpected Reunion” (“Unverhofftes Wiedersehen”), first published in the almanac *Rheinländischer Hausfreund*, 1811; “Kannitverstan” and “How Firebrand Freddy Escaped from Prison One Day and Safely Crossed the Border” (“Wie der Zundelfrieder eines Tages aus dem Zuchthaus entwich und glücklich über die Grenzen kam”), both first published in the almanac *Rheinländischer Hausfreund*, 1809. All three pieces were later collected in *The Treasure Chest of the Rhenish Family Friend*

(Schatzkästlein des Rheinländischen Hausfreundes) (Tübingen: J. G. Cotta, 1811).